if loving you kills me (i would die happy)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46848487.

Rating:
Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Human, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Heavy Angst, Past Child Abuse, Past Sexual Abuse, Past Rape/Non-con, (Non-con not between Adora/Catra), fallout from trauma, Non-Explicit Sex, Bad Sex, Dissociation, Anxiety, Panic Attacks, Disordered Eating, Emotional Constipation, Guilt, Depression, Suicidal Thoughts, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), POV Alternating, Hopeful Ending

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Part 1 of things you could never say

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by Morag

Summary

Adora had an online training about trauma when she started at UNA, about how fear responses look dif ferent in different people, about fight or flight or freeze or flop. She'd seen in referrals how sometimes people got too still, or slumped like they were asleep. Adora thought she knew a trauma response when she saw it.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Fic is fully written, publishing weekly.
>
> Please read the tags, it gets dark pretty much immediately and does not get better for... a while. Heads up that this does open with a clinical but graphic description of child physical and sexual abuse, and that is what the whole thing is about, so proceed or don't accordingly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The film quality is grainy. Stable, but not professional. Shot at a high angle, distorting the angles of the room, warping proportions. Geometric faded floral wallpaper, brown carpet. It looks like every basement on Adora's block growing up. The frame is empty but for a child on the floor and an adult standing.

Adora takes down the details of the child she can see - 5-7 years old, maybe, light brown skin, no visible distinguishing features. Their arms cover their head. The adult is nondescript. 5'8"-10", pale skin, black hair, dressed in feminine clothes. She has a red mask over her face.

The woman is telling the child that they don't deserve to live. The sound is tinny. The child is crumpled small, curled up naked, lying on their side. The woman has a belt wrapped around her hand and she starts to unwind it. "Fucking rabid brat," she says. "What else do I have to do to make you act like a human being?"

Adora stops the video for a moment. Lets out the breath she didn't intend to hold. Post-its ruffle down the side of her monitor, different doodles Glimmer draws when she needs a break. The bottom one is cats sandwiched into macarons. Eleven origami cranes line up under the screen - Catra folds them out of junk mail when she's bored and

sneaks them into Adora's bag. The light catches on the lines where her nails pressed the seams, crisp and clean.

When she takes off her headphones, she can hear Bow typing in the cubicle next to her. He'll take the referral, if she asks him to. He's asked her to take cases that he can't get through, when the kids look too much like his brothers or the adults look too much like his dads. Darla says Adora should ask for help with material that makes her feel small and scared again. "It's okay to have trauma," Darla says, at least every third session. "You just have to know how to take care of yourself."

Catra's safe now. She's an adult and Weaver can't say things like that to her anymore, can't bruise her anymore. She got away and she has a cat and a job that she loves and a girlfriend who tries her best, who she loves despite everything, and she's okay now. If Adora does her job, this woman won't be able to hurt kids anymore either, and maybe Adora can be part of how this kid gets away. Maybe Adora can *do* something this time instead of hiding with her hands over her ears.

She puts her headphones back on. The woman snaps the belt down at the child, hitting their arms, back, legs. The child curls up tighter, knees to elbows. The woman hits them five, six, nine times. The angle makes her look nightmarish, long and spidering. The microphone can't pick up the child crying over the loud cracks, but it breaks through when the woman stops. Red lines are stark on their skin under the film grain.

"You know she doesn't like you," the woman says. "Look at yourself, little monster. She's not going to fuck you no matter how bad you want it."

The child turns against the floor, shaking their head, and the woman comes down to the floor with them. "You know better than to lie to me," the woman says. "You can't keep your hands off of her. It's disgusting. If she knew what you were doing she'd never even look at you again."

The woman hooks a hand around the child's shoulder and flips them on their back, pulls their arms and legs flat. The child squeezes their eyes shut, hair splashed across their face. Adora notes female sex on the report. The woman puts her hand over the child's mouth. Her other hand moves fingers to penetrate, dry, harsh. They grasp at the woman's arm, pushing away, writhing, but she holds them in place. The child screams high pitched and muffled.

The woman pulls the hand from their mouth and punches the child's stomach where a different bruise already blooms. The child screams again, blowing out the microphone on the camera. "You *never* shut up," the woman says, grabbing their hair and wrenching their head up, towards the camera, where Adora can see their face.

Bow calls while Catra's restocking dairy. "Adora must've gotten a really bad one," he says. "She's under the desk and won't talk to any of us."

Catra's been worried about this since Adora took the damn job, but once Adora gets an idea in her head there's no stopping it. Besides, Adora doesn't get a stipend over the summer and they still have to pay rent. But now she's catatonic because they made her watch a baby get raped or some shit so the reasons seem pretty hollow now.

Luckily, Natalie is supervising today and she lets Catra go immediately. She gets there three minutes faster than usual and stops in front of the building, not bothering with a parking spot. The entrance looks the same as every time she's ever dropped Adora off. She tugs at the keys twice before she remembers to put the car in park.

She's never been inside UNA, but Bow is by the door to show her where to go. He's pacing, fidgeting. She doesn't need to know him

well to recognize that he's rattled. The smile he gives her before he goes is very tight. He sees the same things Adora does every day, so if he's shook up something is really wrong.

Thank god Glimmer's with her. Adora's eyes are glassy, almost feverish. A garbage can is at her side and the vomit smell hangs thick in the air. Her collar is dark with sweat. Catra's never seen her like this. Sobs crumple on her face, silent but for gasping breaths, the way they both do.

Catra drops down next to her, work apron rustling. "Hey, princess." Catra brushes tears off Adora's cheek. If she smiles maybe Adora won't notice she's trembling too. "Rough day, huh?"

Adora looks like she might throw up again, or faint, or something. "Sorry," Adora says, hands wrenching together in her lap. Guilt etches into her every inch.

Catra puts her hands on her shoulders, pressing down, like Adora's shrink said would help when she gets like this. "Don't have to apologize for being a person, Adora." This conversation never gets any easier, no matter how many times they have it.

"No." It's hard to hear her, voice clenching around the words. "I didn't know. I'm sorry."

The buzzing starts in Catra's ears. There's about a thousand things it could be. Did she find the cash Catra's been squirreling away? Did Scorpia tell her that they kissed when she was still in school? Did she somehow guess how often, while driving to work, Catra thinks about jerking the wheel off the bridge?

No. Bow said Adora saw something that upset her. They investigate exploited kids, videos of adults and kids. But it's not - Weaver didn't have a camera. Catra would've remembered.

Catra smooths on her calmest face. Adora's in shock. There's no reason for her heart to rabbit like it is. It's not always about Catra.

"We're going to get you home, okay?"

"I saw you," Adora whispers, like it'll hurt her if she says it too loud, and her whole body bows with it under Catra's palms, pulling away, like - like she'd watched Catra melt for the woman who turned Adora's head inside-out.

She didn't see a camera. But she didn't look either, did she? Did she ever look? Did that even occur to her? God, she was so stupid, everyone she's ever met has jerked off to how pathetic she looked when Weaver wrung her out like a wet rag. No one's going to fall for her acting like a person again when they know how nothing she is.

And now Adora, the only person on earth who even matters, has seen her too. She watched the little monster let Weaver ruin it and now Adora knows that Catra's been lying this hole time, hiding the rotting patches so she doesn't know the thing pretending to be her girlfriend is dead. Once the shock wears off she's going to be angrier than Weaver ever was. Catra never should have let her take this job. So fucking *stupid*.

She gets a flash of herself stepping off the sidewalk and getting splattered into a puddle of unrecognizable meat, and it feels like relief. That particular thought hasn't popped into her head for months now, and if she wasn't such a greedy selfish bitch she'd go do it now instead of waiting for Adora to push her in front of the truck.

Catra takes her filthy hands off Adora. "Sparkles," she says, voice even, not looking at Glimmer across the cubicle. There's no point in lying anymore but she's not in charge of the part of her brain that's talking right now. She's a mess of mixed up parts and she never should have thought she could do this. "Can you make sure my car isn't going to be towed? I think it's in a fire zone."

Glimmer takes the trash can when she stands. Even her cotton-candy hair looks exhausted. At least she didn't hear Adora, because she doesn't look disgusted, even holding a bucket of vomit. But she leaves.

As soon as Glimmer disappears, Catra stands up. The mouse rattles too loudly in her shaky hands, but the damn computer is locked, which *obviously, idiot, you think they're going to let you just make this go away? They're always going to know what you are.* Her fingertips fizz on the keyboard. "Password," she says from far away. Copper pools on her tongue, like Weaver's fingers in her mouth. There's too many papers on Adora's desk, colorful sticky notes and forms with little boxes. "What's your password?"

Adora doesn't answer. Even when she's mad, she never ignores Catra. She knows Catra isn't worth talking to anymore, she wants her to shut up and die. It presses behind her eyes, and Catra grinds her jaw to keep the tears there. None of the passwords Adora uses at home work. Her fingers start catching keys she doesn't want as the shaking gets worse. The system locks her out for sixty seconds after her fifth wrong try.

Her stupid cranes are here, a tiny flock under the monitor, from the person she was pretending to be. When she presses one in her palm, the wingtips dig into her skin sharp enough to steady her. She can't feel her face. She doesn't get to ask for things right now, especially not from Adora, but she can't even breathe thinking about Adora seeing it again, *Weaver* seeing it again, even if she's dead before that happens. She doesn't even know what it *is.* It never helped with Weaver when she begged, but Adora's different. "Help me get *rid of it*, Adora, I—"

She hears the ID lanyard rattling before she sees Angella Fujimura. Her words lock tight in her throat when she turns towards her. Adora cares about what Fujimura thinks, even before she was her boss. She wants Fujimura to like her and think she's good at her job, and now Adora's red-eyed on the floor.

When they were still learning addition, Adora spilled a whole jar of counting bears, pattering to the ground around her desk. Ms. Clayton looked at her. Everyone looked at her, and she started to pinch her mouth tight. They had just come back from lunch but Catra's stomach hurt like she hadn't eaten all day. Catra kicked Ameelia's

chair and stole his worksheet and called him a dumbface, and Ms. Layton moved her color down and made her go sit at the orange table and threatened to call the behavior team again, and when everything was settled all the bears were back in their jar. She knows now that no one was going to do anything to Adora, not for that, but she was stupid then. She must be stupid now, because it feels the same, except that this time it's Catra's fault.

Fujmura sits in Adora's chair. "Thank you for coming," she says to Catra, voice soft, the way people talk when they want her to trust them. It's the only way Fujmura has ever talked to her, every time they've visited her big bright house. They were there a couple weeks ago, for Adora's birthday, and Fujmura had asked her bland questions about her job and what she liked to do. She thought Fujmura might have kind of liked her, and either she's lying to them now or she hasn't seen it. The timer ticks down behind Catra and all Fujmura has to do is look to know.

Fujmura turns to Adora, who's still on the floor, by herself. "How are you feeling?"

Adora blinks, eyes huge in her too-pale face. Adora's never been as good at lying as Catra, no matter how much of it she does. "Not great," she says, which Catra's pretty sure Adora would also say if she was bleeding out. Catra hurt her so bad and she's going to hate her so much.

Shivers ripple along Catra's arms. She'd known this was going to happen. She'd always known. She just deluded herself into thinking she'd have more *time.*

Fujmura's still talking to Adora. "You have an emergency session with Darla at 12, it was the earliest I could get you in. She said you have the twenty-four hour number?" Her voice is thick with the same fake concern that Ms. Torres papered on when she tried to get Catra to tell her why they'd called the behavior team on her today. Or maybe, for Adora, it's real. "In case you need it?"

"Yeah," Adora rasps. "I won't need it."

"You're in good hands." Fujmura swivels her eyes to Catra, smile curling like a flame on her lips. Catra reaches for the face for when someone wants her to be wallpaper and finds it already on. The crane wings bite into her palm. Fujmura says, "Adora's so lucky to have you. Partner support is the only way we can do the work we do."

Partner. A drip of sweat crawls across Catra's chest, inching worm-slow on her skin. She remembers that she made Adora fuck her, when she would never in a million years if she'd known where she'd been, and she layers on the smile Fujmura expects to see. "Anything for Adora."

Fujmura says, "Let me walk you out," and panic explodes under Catra's ribs. The computer is still behind her. Fujmura's talking to Adora, and Adora's watching Catra, and she's going to say that it's Catra in the file. And it'll play, and Fujmura will watch Catra go slack and cry for Weaver when she was ten or seven or fifteen or whenever, and she's going to tell Adora how sorry she is that she's dating a corpse.

Catra's ears ring so loud that she can't hear what they're saying. They'll never let her delete it. She never should have thought that she could run away from this when she can't run away from herself. Adora's scanning her face, like she's looking for a reason to spare her execution, and Catra already knows she isn't going to find one. Adora stands up and only wobbles a little. Catra picks up her bag before Adora can fall down again trying to get it. Fujmura's still focused on Adora and Catra can puppet herself down the hallway enough to pretend she exists.

Adora grabs Catra's hand as they pass the elevators. It's not Catra's to have, it never was, and Adora knows that now. If Adora's that desperate for comfort, Catra can at least give her this. Adora can have anything she wants from her right now. She tries to commit the mountains and valleys of Adora's hand to memory again. She needs

to remember how their fingers lace together, if she wants to think about anything good in her last minutes.

When they reach the double doors, Fujmura says, "And Catra, our therapy arrangement covers partners too. Especially in this line of work, a lot of people find it helpful."

Catra's breath sticks in her throat. She was wrong, Fujmura *does* know and she's laughing at her, and she's going to go back to the computer and watch the video again and think about how easy it would be to keep Catra somewhere in her giant house to use whenever she wants.

"Thanks, we'll let you know!" Adora chirps. It's the voice she's always used when Catra fumbles a basic question or jumps at nothing. It means Catra's acting weird, because no matter how hard Weaver tried she could never get Catra to behave like a human being. Adora tried, but she couldn't fix her either, and now she knows she had been wasting her time from the start.

The car is an oven, even though she couldn't have been in the building long. She can pretend that explains the sweat bleeding into her hair and shirt and everywhere, even once the AC starts to roar. Maybe the heat is why her vision goes speckled at the edges and her hands clench on the wheel before they shake off.

Adora says, "I can drive."

Adora hasn't driven her since she taught Catra, less than a week after they moved in together. She doesn't drive unless she has to. Adora doesn't even think Catra can do that anymore, she knows she's barely good for one thing.

Catra can't fall apart until they get home, because Adora really isn't safe to operate a car right now. Catra can grit her teeth and do this one thing for the person she's lied to for years. She snaps the car into drive. "Bow told me you were comatose under a desk, you're not driving."

The radio is too loud when she turns it on, and mostly fuzz but she doesn't fix it. It's almost impossible to get a signal on it anyway. The sizzling static settles into her shoulders, like a heavy pack, and it helps her think through the images of herself dying that rush her brain.

She doesn't have anywhere to go after Adora makes her leave. She has five hundred dollars in the backpack at home, squirreled away over the eighteen months she's earned money, but that won't get her somewhere to live for long. It was stupid to save it in the first place. She crashed with Scorpia when she ran away from Weaver - when Connie made her leave - but Scorpia and Connie are hours away, and they've barely talked in the year since she moved to Bright Moon. If they've seen her with Weaver they don't want anything to do with her anyway. The thought of finally becoming the streetwalker Weaver always said she'd be makes her choke on bile. There's nowhere to go but in the ground. "Don't end up like your mother," her social worker told her once, when Camila Guerra was only missing and not dead yet, and from the beginning there was only one way her life could go.

The anger's starting to hit, bleeding into her hands where she holds the steering wheel, and she has to keep it together long enough to get them home so she doesn't take Adora out with her when she wraps the car around a streetlight. When she gets home, she can keep quiet through everything Adora's going to be livid about and she can pack anything that's going to make Adora miss the girlfriend she thought she had and she can find someplace to die that's more peaceful than she deserves, and *then* she can be angry about how she ruined the only good thing she's ever managed to have.

When they're parked in front of their building, Catra wrenches the keys out of the ignition so violently that the keychains slap against

the steering wheel. The radio snaps off, haze echoing in Adora's ears. It makes everything feel that much less real. Sweat still shimmers on Catra's face. She pops Adora's buckle before Adora gets to it, and that shouldn't annoy her, right now. She still feels a little like she's going to pass out, like when she doesn't hydrate enough and pushes through her exhaustion too hard, but she can handle a seatbelt.

She twists to get her bag out of the back but Catra's already pulling it onto her own shoulder. "I can do that," Adora says, hands empty and useless, like they've always been.

Catra doesn't look at her before she gets out of the car. She slams the door shut and Adora jumps. Catra's halfway through the parking lot before Adora even has her feet back under her. It's muggy out today, thick and heavy, and her clothes cling. Adora runs in the mornings, even more so now that she's only a month away from the start of field hockey season, but there's a familiar ache in her lungs trying to catch up. Catra slips ahead of her, walking up the stairs two at a time.

Adora barely catches the apartment's door before it closes behind Catra. She's facing the door, her back pinned to the wall, head down, arms crossed tight. She has every right to be furious, but she doesn't look it, right now. To someone else, maybe, but not Adora. She looks like her teacher had to make a call home today and Weaver told her not to move while she got the belt from upstairs.

Adora's stomach aches. She doesn't want to think about Weaver anymore, doesn't want to think about what she did when she was done tucking in Adora for the night. Adora doesn't get to decide that, though. "What can I do?" Adora asks.

Catra's still, muscles set. "Do it," she finally says, tension sliding out of her shoulders, voice flatter than Adora's ever heard it, face blank, and for a moment Adora doesn't know who this person is. She looks like something else wearing Catra's face and it's the scariest thing Adora's ever seen.

Adora wants to hug her, pull her head tight to her heart so she can get some of the life from it, but she still has screaming echoing in her ears and she doesn't know what's going to make Catra remember it. She never wants to make her think about Weaver but now she has no idea where the mines are buried. "I don't know what you mean," she says.

"Fine," Catra snaps, anger finally flaring in her eyes, finally something Adora recognizes. "You don't have the guts. *Fine*." She shoves herself off of the wall. Their bedroom door has a cat toy that keeps it from fully closing, so Melog can't trap themself in there when they're home alone, and Catra pushes it open hard enough that it it cracks against the wall.

By the time Adora gets to the bedroom door, Catra's pulling her backpack from high school out of the closet, the one with the roll of cash she thinks Adora doesn't know about. Adora never said anything, because she wanted Catra to feel safe with her, but she never thought she'd actually use it. Catra drops it on top of the dresser and starts to shove her things into it. Adora takes a breath. "Where are you going?"

"Does it matter?" Catra asks, teeth flashing. The part of Adora that's always scared is glad that she's packing, because Adora knows the statistics and it means she's planning to live, but the rest of her is frantic.

Catra punches a shirt into her bag, and it's the one Adora bought her at Pride last summer that says *boo! I'm a lesbian*, with the cartoon ghost that made Catra laugh when she saw it. It was their first time, and they held sweaty hands in a crowd of rainbows, and they raced to see who could get the most free pens. Adora thought they were happy, then, but then Adora's never been very smart. She says, "Don't leave. We - we can talk about this."

Catra rolls her eyes. "I'm *sorry,*" she says, voice rough and cruel. "Is that what you want to hear?"

"No." Adora tucks her arms across her chest so she doesn't try to touch Catra right now, when she's all porcupine edges. She pushes her tongue against her teeth before she talks, so tears don't leak into her voice. "I don't understand. I just want you to talk to me."

"I'm fucking talking." Catra zips the main compartment. "Not my problem if you don't like what I have to say."

Adora tastes metal, and realizes that she's bitten the inside of her lip hard enough to bleed. Catra usually makes her stop when she notices Adora's doing it. "I'm sorry," she says. "I know I- I should have known. I should have stopped it. I'm sorry."

"Oh my god, Adora." Catra's watching her, thrumming with tension, backpack in her hands. "Everything has to be about you, right?"

At least Catra isn't going anywhere, right now. She shifts her grip on her backpack and she stays standing where she is. It's hard to keep a distance from her, when she's still so clearly upset. All Adora wants to do is hug her, tuck her head where it fits under her chin, as if that will fix things. It always felt like nothing really bad could happen as long as they had each other. "Please don't leave," Adora says.

Catra pulls the backpack tight against her chest. Her right hand scrapes light along the opposite forearm, pulling up white lines that will only get harsher if Adora doesn't stop her. Catra freezes, like she hasn't in months, and Adora pulls back the hand she didn't realize she'd reached out. She doesn't *understand.* She doesn't know why Catra would want to disappear again. She knows Adora isn't going to hurt her. She has to know that.

Except Adora did. She did, once. She - they'd been dating for months, and the sound she'd made, low pure pain, that couldn't get out of Adora's head for *days* - Adora thought she hadn't used enough *lube*, for fuck's sake, when she was doing the same thing that made a little kid scream. Of course Catra had never told her anything. She's leaving because she isn't safe with Adora around. She has to run away from her rapist again.

At least Adora makes it to the bathroom before she throws up this time, and it's all water and bile. She's choking, coughing, heart exploding in her chest. She's so cold, sweating. She still hears screaming. Darla taught her exercises for panic attacks but she doesn't even want them, now. She's going to die. She should die. If she wasn't so selfish she'd want to die.

A towel wraps tight around her shoulders and arms, solid pressure that lets her steal a breath. Catra crouches next to her, eyes too wide. "Hey, whoa," she says, and Adora can't stop crying because *why* is she making Catra take care of her right now, she's so manipulative. If she could, she'd push Catra away. "Breathe. I'm sorry. It's okay."

She wants to beg Catra not to go. She wants to beg Catra to forgive her. She wants a lot of things she doesn't deserve to have. "Please," she manages, and she doesn't even know what she's asking for. Catra keeps talking, the low soothing nonsense she does when Adora freaks out, and it's so intensely unfair that Adora's the one falling apart when Catra's suffered for years and Adora did nothing.

"I didn't mean it," Catra says. Her face is damp too. "I won't leave, okay? I'm sorry. I love you."

If Adora was a good person at all, she would be the one to go, to find a corner to die in. Catra's being careful not to touch her, like she's as disgusted as Adora is. Thinking about Catra being alone with what happened crushes Adora's bones into powder, and Adora's supposed to be the one there to help. Adora's not a good person, it turns out.

Grounding exercises still work, even when half of the sensations she has to notice are awful. The bite of bile on her tongue, the cold bathroom floor, the sound of Catra breathing wet. It's all real and it all sucks, but Adora pulls herself together so she can stop being selfish. "Sorry," she says, and it sounds so insignificant it's insulting.

Catra smiles, a little shaky. "Pretty rotten day ," she says. Her hands are still over Adora's sternum, holding the towel tight around her . "Gonna get so much ice cream."

It's a joke. Adora fumbled a pass in the quarterfinal game last season and had a full meltdown about it in Glimmer's dorm room afterwards, and Bow got her rocky road ice cream after. Adora has trouble with ice cream on a good day, and on a bad day it makes her feel like a slow, gurgling slug. She misses her friends suddenly so strongly it feels like it's going to knock her over again. Everyone has to have had enough of taking care of her, today.

"You sure you want me to stay?" Catra asks, words too fast, and this is the moment when Adora needs to tell her to run and not stop. The spot inside her lip that she tore open before flares bright with pain when she finds it between her teeth again. Catra brushes her jaw to prompt her to stop and wipes at Adora's cheeks with the edge of the towel. She didn't know that she was still crying. "Okay ," Catra says, voice gentle. "Okay ."

She puts her forehead on Adora's, long enough that Adora's tired lungs burn a little with the breath she doesn't mean to hold.

Chapter End Notes

Fic title from Ashley by Alita

Edit: changed Glimmer and Angella's last name, it'll be Fujmura going forward.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Last year , Adora's weekend visits filled in the months before Catra could move out of Scorpia's place. They sat together on Scorpia's couch, Adora settling into her like a giant warm blanket. Whatever it was between them, the warm spark that Catra tried to tend herself for so long, felt fragile. She only had Adora for a few days every week. She had to make them count. She had to make sure she didn't break this again.

One Saturday in January , when Scorpia had work until late, Adora was fidgety. She glanced away when Catra saw her watching. She fussed with the sleeve of her BMU sweatshirt, one of the ones she left here for Catra.

Catra tried to ignore the tension cinching her shoulders. Adora wouldn't have driven all the way here to say she never wants to see her again, not when Adora could've easily told her on one of their nightly calls. They were supposed to trust each other.

Then she caught Adora looking at her lips, and she was stupid for not putting it together sooner. She knew Weaver was a liar. Of course this was what Adora wanted. Of course this is how she can keep her.

"Hey , Adora," she said. "Can I kiss you?"

Adora's breath stuttered, and Catra was right, of course. "I- do you want to? I know we're not, like, dating, or - and I don't know if you-"

Catra drew closer and Adora fell into her. It was different than kissing Scorpia - slower, less frantic. Adora had always been careful with

her, and it made her feel like spun glass, in a good way. Adora touched her like it mattered if Catra broke.

With Scorpia, she'd been elated that she was going to be safe, and it was fast. It had felt more like something that was happening to her than something she was doing, but that had been fine, because she hadn't cared about Scorpia that way. Kissing Adora should have been different, because she loved Adora. She should have known how to do this as intuitively as everyone else knew, when they loved someone.

Adora's mouth moved on hers with purpose, and Catra just didn't have the guidebook Adora seemed to. When Adora's mouth opened, she followed. She mimicked back what Adora's lips and tongue did, and Adora hummed so she must have been doing *something* right, but she was guessing at what to do next. Adora held her tighter, breathing harsher, and Catra was consumed with how right it felt to have Adora's body close to hers. What her mouth was doing felt distant, like an echo, and she couldn't bring herself to care.

Adora pulled back first. "Wow." Adora's voice is a little shaky. "God. Why didn't we do that before?"

Catra's heart was revved up weird in her chest, too close to panic, but Adora looked so dazed that she couldn't help but laugh. "Because you're an idiot," she says.

Adora kissed her again. Her hand cupped the back of her head, and for once Catra didn't hate how short her hair was. Adora's fingers stroked the back of her head, and Catra would do anything for that to never stop. Anything else that was happening didn't matter.

"I love you," she said when Adora finally gave Catra her mouth back.

They'd said it plenty of times in the past couple months, hundreds over the years, but Adora's face seized like she'd never heard it before. "I love you *so much.*" Adora's hand had slipped to the back of

her neck, and Catra didn't think about struggling to breathe at all. "How are you so good at this?"

"Beginner's luck?"

"So you haven't - haven't you kissed before?"

Catra kept her face steady. "Who do you think I'm going around kissing?"

Adora smiled before she nestled her head in the hollow under Catra's chin. "I guess I- I don't know . I thought maybe you were dating Scorpia? I didn't want to assume you weren't."

Catra only kissed Scorpia once, and she isn't sure Scorpia even remembers. Scorpia had been pretty upset, the night Bonnie hauled her out of the basement and into Scorpia's car , voice gravel and scalp bleeding where Weaver's scissors had been careless. A lot of it's hazy , but she can remember Bonnie talking fast, angry , and when Catra had tried to make a move on Scorpia a few days later, she'd said *not yet*. After Adora came back, Scorpia had told Catra she was happy for her, even though Catra insisted it wasn't like that. Scorpia said she could still stay and Catra didn't want to push at the thing between her and the sidewalk. "You thought I was dating Scorpia and cuddling you all the time was just cool with her?"

"I don't know!" Adora's cheek was hot on Catra's skin. "I don't - I figured you would've, you know , done something at some point. I mean you could have - you're so hot, you could have anyone you want."

Catra went to high school. She knew what that meant Adora wanted to do to her. Catra should have wanted that too, if she loved her. It was a wonder Adora couldn't feel her heart jittering inside her ribs. It was okay. She'd - she could do it, it wasn't going to be like before, Adora probably didn't want her to disappear , Adora wouldn't hurt her . Even if she did, Catra could still do it. If Adora wanted her to cut of f

her arm she'd figure out how to do it. She'd figure out how to do anything that would make Adora stay.

And she wanted this, she had to, she always had - one of the earliest things she knew about herself is that she'd been a little monster who wanted to touch Adora in a way a normal kid doesn't. That's what Weaver had said, that's why that kid deserved what W eaver did.

Catra found the strip of skin between Adora's shirt and her jeans, warm under her fingertips. She wasn't a kid anymore. This was how to keep Adora there. "Who else would I have wanted?" she asked, and it felt dangerous leaving her mouth.

"I guess I figured - I don't know ." Adora laid a kiss on her neck and shrugged, the same solid weight on her chest, and the tension in Catra's gut unwound. "I hooked up with a girl from another team, last fall. t didn't mean anything. And I haven't, since I found you, because I- I couldn't think about anyone else if I had you." Catra didn't know where to even *begin* with that sentence. "It's okay . We can figure it out together. We'll take it slow . I want to take it slow ."

Catra didn't want to give Adora enough time to realize what a mistake she was making, but Adora had said what she wanted. She kissed the top of Adora's head, and Adora pressed further into her arms. She wanted to be anything Adora would keep. "Whenever you're ready ," she said.

They went on their first date the next weekend, twenty minutes away in Alwyn so they didn't have to worry about running into anyone they knew. Adora got to hold Catra's hand in the car and concentrate on not crashing. t still felt a little like she was going to wake up any minute. She played the dumb playlist she made, that she'd listened to over and over on the drive down just to confirm that it was the

normal amount of sappy for a date, but with Catra next to her it felt much stupider. Catra smiled though, so she couldn't think it was too silly. Adora didn't know how she was supposed to watch the road when Catra was smiling right next to her while the music said *you'll always be my happy ending.*

When Adora was twelve, they'd been buying school supplies. She'd held her notebooks and folders tight, waiting for Weaver to come back from the food section with the cart, and she'd watched Catra and Bonnie squabble about who should get the last red binder. Catra's hair spilled wild over her shoulders, and she smirked as she spun another quip at Bonnie, and Adora's heartbeat kept stuttering and swelling. *You are the best thing that's ever been mine*, the song over the store speakers had said, and Adora understood that all the way down to her bones, and then it said, *I fell in love,* and - oh. That was what that feeling meant.

It was huge, for a moment, and it should have been scary but it wasn't at first - it felt like finally getting something *right*. The fear set in quick, and she couldn't look at Catra in the store again without panic jittering her fingers, but they sat next to each other in the car and Adora couldn't feel scared of how giddy and peaceful she was all at once. They played Slap together later, cross-legged on Adora's bed. Catra was always faster than her, so Adora's hand was always on top of hers when a pair came up, and Adora never wanted to pull her hand away.

Two years later, she tried to be as casual as possible when she told Catra at lunch that she liked girls, actually, and Catra said that she did too. Adora took another bite of dubious cheeseburger so she couldn't say something dumb, and Catra made a joke about Mr. Stubbs and how he was just risking fate by teaching shop, and - obviously liking girls didn't have to mean *her.* Adora was acutely aware of exactly how many girls in their school were more clever and attractive and fun than her. Catra deserved someone who was as great as she was, and Adora was just a lump of awkward angles and more awkward pauses.

Besides, Adora was supposed to be her sister. Adora was being weird and creepy for wanting Catra to love her back. Catra narrowed her eyes, just the slightest bit, and Adora asked what finger Catra would rather lose if she had a power tool accident, and they didn't talk about girls again.

Now, they walked in downtown Alwyn making fun of the things in store windows that they couldn't afford. Catra grabbed Adora's hand and put their held hands in one of Catra's pockets, because she said she was cold without gloves. Adora said, "I'll keep you warm," and she didn't die of how crazy she sounded, how crazy she felt. Catra's hand squeezed around hers and she pointed at a mannequin whose dress had the worst pattern Adora had ever seen. Adora slept on Scorpia's floor that night and dreamed about how soft Catra went in her arms, sharp edges melted smooth. She was always sore after a night on the floor, but it was worth it. It was worth more than that.

Before she left the next evening, she was struggling to outrun the panic enough to say what she'd been thinking all day. "Spit it out," Catra said, because she knew Adora better than she knew herself sometimes.

Adora's face was hot before she even said it. "Are we girlfriends?" It felt all at once too much and not enough, but she didn't know another word for what she wanted. She couldn't introduce Catra to anyone as her *everything.*

"I hope so," Catra said, smirking a little, "because if I don't have a girlfriend you gotta tell me who I've been making out with." They kissed again, and it turned Adora into a goofy pop song just like the first time, all fireworks and syrup and morning sunrise. That feeling stayed with her the whole way home, nestled in her core, warming her all the way out to her fingertips.

Scorpia bought Catra a cake for her nineteenth birthday in February, with thick white swirls along the top. "I didn't know what your favorite kind was," she said, "and you did not notice all the hints I dropped to get you to tell me."

Catra didn't entirely believe that, because Scorpia wasn't capable of subtle, but it was decent for one of those vanilla cakes with the sprinkles in the batter. She hadn't had anyone other than Adora really acknowledge her birthday since her teachers stopped posting a list on the wall. Last year, Adora had bought her a chocolate bar at the convenience store they passed on the way to the bus, and Catra had made it last two weeks. This year, her phone pinged with pictures of cakes with candles and animals holding hands from Adora all day. They texted a lot, during the week, but it was even more than usual, and Catra grinned like an idiot when she ate her sandwich in the breakroom. *I miss you like the moon would miss the stars*, the latest text read, and Catra's cheeks were hot when she checked them with the back of her hand. She'd never understood the sappy shit until it was Adora doing it, and now she couldn't control how ridiculous it made her feel.

Since Adora's field hockey season ended, she drove to Thaymor every weekend Catra wasn't working. Catra kept checking with Scorpia that it was fine, since it was her apartment floor that Adora dropped her sleeping bag on most Friday nights, but Scorpia always said yes and her face got tight when she asked the same question too often, so she stopped. Adora's housing agreement ended in June, and while the rest of the team stayed in the dorms their scholarships pay for, Adora insisted that she wanted to go off-campus. She said she wanted to live with Catra again, for real this time. "I don't want to wake up without you anymore," she said, because she just *said* things like that.

Catra told Adora that she loved her all the time, like it was a spell she could cast to keep her, and Adora said it nearly as often. They kissed a lot, too, and usually it was good. Sometimes Adora's hands wandered far enough to make her blink out for a while, but Adora

didn't seem to notice, and it was worth it to come back to Adora there. Her body wasn't usually the way she left it, her own hands and lips repeating whatever Adora's were doing, so it was okay. Adora always looked so content, and it felt like Catra's skin must have glowed with how it felt to know that something was finally enough for Adora, she was enough. Adora had always made her feel like she was something alive.

Catra doesn't remember a time before she loved her, but she realized *something* in kindergarten, when they were young enough that they still read books on the carpet sometimes, before Weaver called her a monster. They watched a movie one day and Ms. Bell said they could sit wherever they wanted. Catra and Adora hadn't been allowed to sit together since the first day of school, when they couldn't stop talking to each other. Catra glared at the other kids at the red table until they left, and Adora pulled up Serenity's chair close enough to sit leg-to-leg, shoulders together.

Adora was watching the movie but Catra wasn't. Adora looked so special, colors splashing on her face from where the movie projection reflected off the whiteboard. There was a freckle on her neck, about halfway down, and it felt like a secret that only Catra knew. She wanted to touch it to see if it was smooth like the ones Catra saw on her own face in the mirror, or raised like the one on Adora's arm. She wanted Adora to be right there with her forever. Music started out of the fuzzy speakers and Catra couldn't imagine wanting to watch anything other than Adora.

All the kids laughed at something. Adora's hand jumped up to hide her giggle, and she looked at Catra. Her eyes were so alive and happy and Catra burst with something soft and warm. She tapped her forehead on Adora's before she realized what she'd done. Her face burned and her heart hammered loud. She was so weird and Adora was going to tell all the other kids how weird she was and what if all the other kids had seen what she just did, what was *wrong* with her-

Adora's hand came down from her mouth, stopped hiding her smile and the gap in her teeth. She tapped back, hard enough to sting, and grinned wide. When she looked back at the screen, her shoulder stayed tight against Catra's, leg warm along hers. Catra didn't know the words for how she felt, but it felt bigger than best friends, bigger than sisters, too big to figure out while the movie played against her ears. Usually, feelings that were too big for her exploded out as screaming and hitting and throwing things, but this time it was good. It felt like when she earned something out of the prize box in Ms. Bell's cabinet and she had something that was hers. It felt like Adora was hers.

That coal-bright feeling stayed, even when Weaver saw it and told her what was wrong with her. It shouldn't have made her happy, anymore, now that she knew it was bad, but it did, and she couldn't figure out how to give it up. It was like getting air after Weaver dunked her head in the bath. She stopped crawling into Adora's bunk for months, when she was scared she'd wet Adora's bed too, but eventually she needed Adora there more than she worried about that. Even when it got her in trouble, her thoughts were too jittery to sleep anywhere else. Everything really bad happened when Adora wasn't there.

By the time Adora drove down on Friday, Catra had only gotten through about two-thirds of the cake Scorpia bought, and that was after she'd made Scorpia take half. It was sweet, cloying, and it stopped tasting good after the third bite, but Scorpia had bought it for her when she didn't have to. Adora made a quick face at the cake that she must have thought Catra didn't see, and Catra didn't offer her any. She gave Catra gloves, fingerless so she could still use her phone, and chocolates in a fancy box. "I've never had these, but Bow said they were good, and I know you need gloves-"

"It's great," Catra said, around the lump in her throat, and put them on. Her fingertips still brushed Adora's calluses when they held hands. She still hadn't met Bow, though she'd heard plenty about him, and he was right about the chocolates. They went to Adora's

car later to make out, and it was cold but they were wearing their coats and Adora's hands were warm on her face, and she didn't black out once.

Glimmer went home for spring break at the end of March, and Adora picked up her girlfriend to stay with her this time instead of crashing in a sleeping bag on Scorpia's floor. Catra's hair was getting longer, scabbed patches faded under the new growth. She'd let Adora trim it with Scorpia's clippers a month earlier, to even it out, so she could start leaving the hat at home as it got warmer. She still got tense when she got compliments, but it was getting better. Catra was getting better, and she wanted to come to Adora's school and see the rest of her life, and it was nothing Adora thought she could have.

Adora had saved a week's worth of her stipend, so she could afford to show Catra everything she wanted to. Glimmer had left her student ID on her desk, after very pointedly telling Adora that she wouldn't need it and she had meal dollars that would expire, but Adora left it where it was. She got Catra the super-sweet, fat-rich coffee that Glimmer liked, the one that was almost 500 calories and she'd have to run for hours to get rid of, just to see her face. It was the same scrunched, astounded look Adora had in the picture Glimmer took, after she'd switched their drinks. "Shit," Catra said, "what is this, pure syrup?"

"And cream, and caf feine." Adora smiled and it felt right on her face for once. "And chocolate? I think mocha has chocolate."

"It's got the whole candy store." Catra made another face, but she took another pull on the straw. Mermista came in, wearing the look she has at early practice even though it's nearly noon, and Adora got caught up bringing her lives together. Catra still stood closer to her

around new people but it was okay, she joked with Mermista too, she was getting better.

Adora had put her spare pair of sheets on Glimmer's bed, even though Glimmer had teased that she was missing the point of having her girlfriend over. They'd shared a bed a thousand times, even into high school, but everything felt charged now. Adora wanted the same things she wanted in high school, but now there was a chance she could actually *have* it, instead of imagining it by herself in her room at night and feeling guilty after. As it got later they kept lying on Adora's bed, talking, barely far enough away from each other to justify if someone came in. Not that anyone would. Adora's floor was mostly empty. Even her RA was gone. Adora couldn't stop thinking about how alone they were.

She had a twin bed, but it felt huge compared to the couch. The lights were dying and dim, orange fluorescent, and it made shadows on Catra's face. She was laughing at some stupid story Adora told about her English class, a story she forgot before Catra finished laughing. She made Adora feel like she was writing the poems that sounded so dumb when they read them aloud in class, like her heart was a singing bird or an apple tree or a rainbow shell.

Adora kissed her, and it felt different this time. Catra's hands sifted along her back, along the hooks on the bra Adora had chosen instead of her typical sports bra this morning because she'd thought it would be easier to get out of. It'd felt silly then. Now the thought made her feel like she might explode. She pulled back long enough to say, "You can take it off. If you want."

Catra moved carefully, like she was worried about tearing something, and her fingertips skimmed along the lines of Adora's deltoid when she lifted Adora's shirt over her head. Adora reached for Catra's hem and Catra went soft and pliable under her hands.

"Are you - is this okay?" Adora asked. Catra nodded, and her breath was rushing quick like Adora's. She ran her fingers along the

waistband of Adora's leggings, the way she sometimes fussed with something when she got nervous. "Only if you want to. Do you?"

"Obviously ," Catra said, and the fussing changed to pulling.

t moved fast, after that. Catra didn't seem to know what to do with her hand, once they'd gotten under each other's clothes, and Adora wondered if Catra had never done this to herself. "Like this," Adora said, moving her own hand on Catra's clit in circles the way it had always worked for Adora. Catra's echo was a little clumsy but it was still a thousand times better than what Adora imagined when she had trouble sleeping, because it was really Catra, she was really here. The freckles across her nose were close enough to count, if Adora wasn't too busy with better things.

They must have come at the same time, because Adora snapped back from her orgasm to Catra moving Adora's fingers away with her spare hand. Catra shook hard and Adora realized that she didn't know if Catra had ever orgasmed before, if she'd never touched herself. The feeling was as strange as it was pleasant, the first time. "Sorry ," Adora said, drawing her sticky hand away , brushing her clean one against Catra's neck. "I was distracted." Catra tilted her chin against her hand. She was gasping a little, face twitching, and it was like a magic power to make her feel as special as Adora did. "I love you," Adora said.

"I love you so much," Catra said, sounding a little choked, and it glowed extra-bright this time.

They didn't use the other bed. They tried again the next afternoon, faint light coming in under the blinds, and this time Adora focused. Catra melted out under her hands like butter, and Adora never wanted to do anything else.

Catra took the bus back to Thaymor Monday evening, to make it to work on Tuesday. They kissed at the bus stop and Adora said she'd see her on Friday. "Can't wait," Catra said, and she smiled the way she hadn't a few months ago, like things were getting better .

Chapter End Notes

Works cited:

Adora's playlist has Finding You by Kesha

Gay awakening lyrics are from Mine by Taylor Swift (if I had to have a gay awakening to a tswift song so does Adora)

Poem referenced is A Birthday by Christina Rossetti

Chapter 3

t takes a while for Adora to calm down. She looks like she did when Catra picked her up this morning, and Catra tries but it's obvious that Adora's too upset for her to help much. They stay sitting on the floor , and Catra puts as much pressure through the towel as she can, pulling it tight around Adora's shoulders. She doesn't think, if Adora's already vomiting, that she actually wants something like Catra to touch her right now. Eventually, slowly, her face smooths out, hands going loose, breathing steady and even through the exercises her therapist taught her. She manages to get herself under control again even though Catra can't fully keep her selfish skin away from hers.

Adora's therapist has helped her a lot in the last couple months. Not enough, if she still wants Catra, but a lot. Not having to leave feels like something Catra isn't good enough to have and she can't have it for long. t doesn't make any sense. Adora's going to get her head back on, get therapy, talk to her friends who love her. She's going to realize she's wrong.

Thinking of therapy. Catra shifts to pull her phone out of her pocket. The office is in the same building as UNA, so she knows it's not far . "Y ou okay to get up soon?" Catra asks. "W e need to leave in fifteen minutes."

Adora's distant stare snaps back into focus. "Oh. Okay . Yeah." She shrugs under the towel like she's trying to shake it off, and Catra finally lets it go. Her fingers are cramped. "I need to call to cancel, thanks for reminding me."

"Y ou're not canceling," Catra says.

Adora has that look on her face, the set to her jaw that means that she's locking in on something and she's not going to hear anything against it. She is the most stubborn person Catra has ever met, and

sometimes it's something she loves about her , and sometimes it makes her want to shake her until what's left of her brain falls out.

"This isn't up for debate."Catra stands up, back grumbling about how long she spent crouched on the floor. Adora desperately needs therapy right now - someone needs to tell Adora to put herself first for once in her life - but if Catra says it that way she'll never go. "Y our boss made you the appointment, it's part of your j b."

Adora levers herself to her feet. Her eyes dart to the backpack that Catra dropped in the hallway outside the bathroom. "I don't want to leave you right now,"Adora says.

Catra *should* run while Adora's gone, because it's going to be so much easier for both of them that way, but she can't bring herself to go anywhere, do anything, when Adora still wants her. She'll take the stay of execution for as long as she can. It's not like the bridge won't be there later. "I promise you can leave me unattended for an hour . I said I'd stay , right?"

"I know ."Adora's face doesn't change, because of course she doesn't trust Catra anymore, not when she found out she's been lying their whole lives.

Catra doesn't snarl, or yell, or do any of the things she wants to do, even though she's been a knife's edge away from doing all of those things ever since Bow called this morning. "Get me a fucking babysitter if you need to,"Catra says, more angrily than she wants to. "I f I have to call your friends I'm going to tell them you're threatening to cancel therapy, and they won't be as nice as me."

"They're *our* friends,"Adora says, but she's pulling out her phone.

Adora has Gatorade powder in a tub on top of the fridge next to her protein shit, and Catra shakes it with water in Adora's dumb shaker bottle, and smacks it on the table hard enough to feel it in her shoulder. Adora's phone is back in her pocket when she comes to the kitchen. "Drink it,"Catra says. It's one of the few things Adora will

reliably consume no matter how stressed she is, and when she eyes it sideways Catra fists her hands. "You've got nothing in you, we're not doing this."

If she's mean to Adora right now, she might melt down again, and then they're back where they started and she really won't go to therapy. But it makes Catra so *angry* when Adora won't eat, and she doesn't have room to be angry about anything else today. She can't even think about what it means that she's on the internet somewhere, whining like a dog, fucking stupid kid that had teeth she couldn't figure out how to use, a bug squashed on the floor with its guts spilling out.

It's like when she broke her arm - it didn't hurt right after the cracking sound, like her brain knew that the enormity of it was too much, but she was certain that she couldn't let anything touch it, couldn't move it, even though she didn't know why. Then Weaver grabbed her wrist again and *then* it hurt, *then* black spots popped in front of her eyes and she woke up in the hospital to someone telling her she fell out of a tree. But for a moment she just knew something was wrong and she couldn't go near it.

Adora must see how close she is to losing it, because she picks up the bottle and drinks. Her throat bobs when she swallows. She sets the bottle down half-empty. "Glimmer says she's on her way. I'm sorry. I know it's stupid."

"Gonna tell your therapist you said that." Catra feels a little less unsteady, seeing the liquid level lower than it was. She should apologize. The words tangle on her tongue. There's too much to apologize for. "Not supposed to say sorry when you didn't do anything."

Adora's lip twitches where she's pulling the inside between her teeth, and she winces so small someone else wouldn't notice, just her eyebrows. She drinks the rest of the bottle, and if she bit through the skin earlier it probably stings. "I can drive myself," she says, and Catra nods, stomach dropping. It's starting.

Her phone vibrates in her pocket. Glimmer says she's close. Catra tells Adora she needs to go before she's late. "Love you," Adora says, like they always do before they have to go separate ways, and Catra echoes it back. They usually kiss goodbye too. Adora doesn't kiss her today. She knows where that mouth has been, now.

When Glimmer comes, she has a large vinyl-covered rectangle, longer than one of her arms. It thwaps when she drops it on the floor. She says, "One of us is going to hit this thing, I don't really care who."

If someone else hits something around Catra right now, she's going to crawl out of her skin, so she tells Glimmer to pick up the bag. It feels good under her fists, soft enough that her punches don't reverb down her arm but firm enough to feel like she's hitting something. If she lets herself hear the smacks of her hand on the bag, she doesn't know what's going to happen, so she growls with every strike.

She doesn't even know where the camera could have been. It would have had to be in the basement room, but she'd been stuck in that room so many times, tore it apart for hours. It was barely twice as wide as she was tall in each direction, the last time she measured it, when she was fourteen and stir-crazy. She should have found a camera. If she hadn't been so stupid she'd have found the camera that must have been there.

"Wow," Glimmer says when Catra stops to gasp. "We have to get you guys one of these. You make it work harder than I do."

Catra fills two of their mismatched mugs with water and gives one to Glimmer, who sits on the couch and pretends she isn't watching her. "A picture will last longer," Catra says, and Glimmer winces much more obviously than Adora had, and. She must know too. Maybe Adora told her. Or her mom *showed* her, played the funny parts over again, the keening alien noises Catra used to make, how stupid she looked.

From her expression, Glimmer knows she gave herself away. "I'm sorry," she says. She fidgets with the handle of her mug. *I don't need chill, I need more coffee,* it says. Someone on Adora's team gave it to her at the end of the last season. Catra deserves some kind of medal for not breaking it yet. "We don't have to talk about it. We can, if you want, but I know that's not why I'm here."

She should be angry at Glimmer. Adora came home one day that April, while Catra was looking for more shifts to cover before rent was due and trying not to panic about when Adora's scholarship stipend stopped next month, and said that she found the perfect summer job. "It's Glimmer's mom, we know her, she does *amazing* work." The pay was really good too, almost double what Catra made at the store. When Adora explained what the job was, Catra swallowed the sludge in her throat. "I think it'll be good for me," Adora said. "I think I'll feel better if I can help people. Help, uh, kids that need it." And Catra said good luck on the interview and Adora kissed her and later she let the monster into her bed.

Glimmer is Adora's friend. Adora's going to be upset if she comes home and Catra's chased her babysitter away. And punching the bag helped, made everything feel less like the world was ending.

"I didn't know there was a camera." The words fight their way out, scraping. "We wouldn't've let Adora work there if I did."

"I told her not to do it. I told Mom not to hire her." Glimmer runs a hand through her pink hair, shimmery strands catching in the afternoon light. "She internalizes *everything*. And I've been helping Mom for over a year now, and some of the referrals are really physically violent too, and I, uh, I knew she had some background with that at least."

The laugh bursts out of Catra, and Glimmer's face pinches. "Adora was the good one, she was fine."

Glimmer lifts her eyebrows at her. "You don't believe Adora's fine."

"No, she's obviously a disaster , but not because of *that*." Adora's problem is that she can't ever stop, that she doesn't let anybody help her, that Weaver made her think that she had to be the best at everything all the time and when she isn't she freaks. When she's stressed she doesn't eat or sleep and she keeps plowing ahead until her body gives out. And she's always let Catra manipulate her , and she wants to *keep* her, apparently, so she's obviously not well. "Adora got told some messed up shit, yeah, but she didn't get, like - growing up the only thing that was 'physically violent' to her was me." She makes the air quotes as big as she can. "That's not *baggage."*

"That's - both of you are so - fuck." Glimmer drinks like she has something stronger than water in her cup. "I'm not the right person to unpack all that and now is *definitely* not the time, but." She frowns, fusses the edge of her lip. "Can you trust me that it's not good for a kid to be around the shit that was happening in your house even if she wasn't the target?"

Catra thinks about the one and only time Weaver got rough with Connie, after her mother lost her rights and Connie smashed a plate and Weaver knocked her to the ground. Adora pulled on Catra's arm until it hurt and couldn't stop shaking long after they got to her room, even though Weaver had barely touched Connie. Catra shrugs. She *doesn't* trust Glimmer, but she doesn't sound wrong.

"Well. That's what I was worried about. But. Mom said she passed the pre-employment testing."

Catra lets her finger circle the rim of her mug. "Adora doesn't listen."

Glimmer grimaces. "No. She definitely doesn't."

They spend another twenty minutes with the body shield. Catra punches until she can't feel her hands anymore. Glimmer never does get a turn to hit it, but she shakes her arms when they're done like she's been working out too. They make hot chocolate after , some youtuber mixing a vat of lipgloss together in the background, and

Glimmer doesn't say anything about how Catra keeps looking at the door, waiting for it to open.

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talk to her, Glimmer's text says, but Adora doesn't know how to do that. They haven't said Weaver's name since Catra took off her hat in Scorpia's living room, and even the story she told then was barely a skeleton, only enough to know that Adora's phone call had made Weaver nearly kill her. Catra doesn't talk about her, and Adora doesn't want to either, and so they don't.

Darla makes Adora talk. When she goes in today and she tells Darla what happened at UNA, she has to pull the words like teeth. "She was - little," Adora says, stomach churning, and she manages not to throw up the Gatorade Catra made her drink.

"That's a lot," Darla says. Adora laughs and Darla doesn't look at her like she's crazy, she never does, even when Adora says awful nightmare things in session like two weeks ago when she said *I loved our foster mother.*

She saw Weaver have her hands on Catra so many times, pushing her around, pulling her downstairs, hitting her when she didn't have the belt handy. Weaver never even wore the belt, it was just something she had for punishing kids, and that kid was *always* Catra. Weaver said it was because she was bad, she didn't listen, she couldn't behave, and Adora drank up everything. Even when she was scared of Weaver, which she should have known wasn't normal, she'd still loved her. It feels like poison pooling in her stomach, seeping, choking. Maybe she believed her because they were the same, and that's why it was so easy for Adora to rape Catra too.

Darla doesn't want her to talk about all of that, today. "Crisis management first," she says, and the word feels at once too big and

nowhere near enough.

They spend most of the session talking about Adora - how she managed the panic attacks today, what she's going to do on her medical leave, who was in her support system if she needed them. "Catra can't - I can't make her help me right now," Adora says.

"That's a great reason to use your other supports," Darla says, "so it doesn't fall on her. You have other people who will want to help."

Adora opens her mouth to tell Darla what she did, why she shouldn't *get* help, but her lying tongue sticks. Catra's already been laid so bare today, and she can't pile more violations on top of what's already out. Adora doesn't know if that makes sense or if it's the excuse she's telling herself to try to get away with it.

They don't have a lot of time to talk about everything else. Darla told her to follow Catra's lead for now, to only talk about what Catra starts. "You have a lot of questions," Darla says, "but she may not be equipped to answer them right now." Adora's supposed to come back the day after next, at her regular Thursday time, and Darla gives her the card with the crisis line number again. "You're both going to get through this," Darla says, and Adora wants to believe her as easily as she believed the monster that raised her.

Glimmer stays for a little bit, once Adora gets home, and she's obviously struggling too but Adora can breathe while she's there. Catra's backpack isn't in the hallway anymore. Catra is drinking hot chocolate and making half-hearted jokes about the video Glimmer put on, something about candle-related life hacks, and Adora sees Weaver's hands on her whenever she blinks. Her own hot chocolate is so sweet it turns her stomach, but Catra and Glimmer get upset when she doesn't eat, so she drinks enough that there's a line on the inside where the liquid level has dropped, in case one of the other two check.

Glimmer has to leave, eventually, and she hugs Adora longer than usual. "Call me," she says, and Adora promises that she will. Catra

doesn't like hugs from anyone but Adora, never has, so Glimmer doesn't even try.

They make instant ramen for dinner, and Adora mixes her protein powder in a glass of milk. "You're impossible," Catra says, but she sounds fond. The soup steams on Adora's face and she's starting to think that the evening will be okay when Catra talks again. "What happens next?"

Adora looks down at her bowl. "With, uh-"

Catra sweeps her spoon through her broth. "At your job. What happens?"

Adora eats, mostly to buy time. The soup scalds her lip. "Angella finishes the reviews we can't handle. So she'll take care of it."

Catra's face sets, like it does when she's panicking. "What does that mean?"

They run identifying personal and environmental features through the missing and known exploited child database. If that brings up a match, UNA can notify the law enforcement contact that they have additional material. If it doesn't bring up a match, they have to check against the national list of unidentified child cases, the ones that the crown police are working on. That's most of what Angella does, anymore.

"Angella tries to find the kid," she says, like if she keeps it general she can pretend this isn't about her girlfriend. "So she can make sure they're safe, now."

"So if-" Catra grimaces, but tries again, "so if they tell her they're fine, she'll delete it?"

Adora doesn't understand why she wants the video gone. It makes Adora feel vulnerable too, and it must be twice as awful for Catra, but it's evidence. Adora is sick at the thought of Weaver in prison,

because Adora's a terrible person who can't figure out how to hate her, even now. Catra definitely hates her, prickles sharp whenever anything related to her comes up. She has every reason to want Weaver to be stabbed in a public shower and Adora should too. "They can't just - it's proof of like three serious felonies. It could put her away for a long time."

"Oh, three whole crimes." Catra scoops noodles onto her spoon and watches them slip back into the bowl, scowling. "Imagine that."

"It's not like before," Adora says. Her bowl is just this side of too hot, fine for a moment but uncomfortable to hold for long. "There's evidence now. No one can say we're lying this time."

"Yeah, thank god she had a camera running for that," Catra snaps, flush rising in her cheeks. "Glad I could help."

Sometimes, talking to Catra feels like handling a grenade, and Adora doesn't know if the pin's in or not. Adora doesn't trust herself with Catra right now without making her explode. "We should talk about this later," Adora says, tension creeping up her spine, because this is the moment when Catra either lets go or digs in for a fight.

"Sure," Catra says, face twisting, and it's going to be an argument, then. "Give your boss enough time to really savor it."

Adora wants this conversation to be over, but she can't let Catra imply that, not about Angella. She feels like she does when she runs long enough to get sick on the side of the street, dizzy. "You know it's not like that."

"I mean, she runs the place, I bet she gets the best selection. Performance-wise I'm sure I wasn't-"

"Stop." The nausea's getting worse. Adora doesn't want to be here anymore. "Angella's never been anything but nice to you. Why would you even say that?"

Catra stabs her spoon into her soup, jaw tense. Her lips press thin. Her other hand skitters back and forth on the table.

Adora has one job, and now Catra's mad. "We'll talk about this later," Adora says.

Catra shrugs, stirring her soup instead of eating it. She doesn't speak again. They just bought milk yesterday, but the stuff in Adora's mug tastes sour, and Catra doesn't seem to notice when she drinks the soup broth but puts the noodles in the fridge. Catra brings her pillow to the couch later, presumably so she doesn't have to risk being anywhere near Adora, and Melog's running their midnight laps through the apartment by the time Adora falls asleep.

The stage at Hayes High isn't that big. Catra never did a show there, but Bonnie worked lights on a few and she'd make her come during tech week to help place spike tape and finish props. Adora was usually wrapped up in the end of field hockey or softball season then, anyway. This stage is clear of markers or props, and Bonnie would never have made the stage so bright. The house lights are down, but the audience murmurs loud enough for her to hear.

She turns around and Weaver is watching her, eyes glinting behind the mask, smoke pluming around her, and the scream can't leave her throat. Weaver walks to her, knots one hand in her long hair and fists the other in her shirt, and Catra's muscles listen to her as well as they ever have.

She's on her back, and the carpet of the stage rasps against her bare shoulder blades. Weaver pries open her mouth and stabs her fingers into the back of her throat, nails knife-sharp, cutting wet but too far back to taste the blood at first, and her cry bubbles and

gurgles. Catra's body spasms and the shadows bend to tie her down, make her stay still.

Blood splatters on her bare chest when she coughs. "God, you never shut up," Weaver says, pinning her hands over her mouth until her jaw snaps and collapses. Someone in the audience moans like Adora does right before she finishes. She's in a bed of her own hair, and it scratches and cuts like wire.

The spotlight is blinding, making the colors vivid against the darkness of the audience. "Smile," Adora says, masked face floating beside Weaver's. "I love you." Adora takes off what she needs to, and Weaver's eyes glow when she adjusts Catra's ruined face to go where Adora wants it.

She's curled up when she wakes, every muscle tight, biting her knuckles so she can be quiet. She can taste metal and it makes her stomach churn. Her gut aches like it's bruise-mottled. If she moves she'll fall apart. Her knees dig into the back of the couch, and it's good she's quiet so she doesn't wake Scorpia. If she's the only one awake she's safe. She must have been in trouble and she doesn't know what Scorpia did but-

Something comes between her and the back of the couch. Warm, furry, rumbling. It's confusing, for a moment, because the apartment should be just her and Scorpia, but when her cat rubs their face on her chin she remembers where she is, what happened, that Scorpia never made her hurt. It takes a few minutes, but finally Catra can shift enough to run her dry fingers along Melog's side.

Melog has gravitated to her ever since they visited the shelter. "They're so sweet to people but they don't get along with the other cats," the volunteer said. "It's hard to find someone who wants to adopt and doesn't have at least one already." Adora jokes that they know "cat" is in her name, and Catra responds that Melog would fight her if they did. It's not her least favorite animal comparison, even if it isn't true. Melog has claws and knows how to use them.

When she can, she sits up. The teethmarks are deep enough to bruise but didn't break the skin. One of her knuckles is split from the bag earlier. Adora's laptop is on the table. She insists that it's theirs, but her scholarship money paid for it, so normally Catra doesn't touch it. Catra's phone was thirty-five dollars and it freezes if she tries to open a website with too many pictures. She can really only use the browser to check her shift schedule or the bus routes, and that was all she needed to do before she knew that Weaver had put her on the internet.

She didn't have a computer in high school, but she overheard enough to use the private browser. She doesn't even know what search terms to use. It's not like it's going to be under her name. Google turns up websites called Keeping Your Children Safe Online, articles about when to take a kid to the doctor, clips of blonde women with pigtails and long socks with titles about stepdaughters and babysitters. She triple-checks that the computer is muted before she opens "Little Girl Gets Punished." A white woman older than Catra is now holds a stuffed animal and looks at a man her age, talking so much that she's already given away. The fear on her face is so fake that Catra laughs before she realizes she's doing it.

She's being stupid. It's not going to be that easy to find. She doesn't even know what Adora saw, maybe it was barely anything, and maybe Weaver only filmed it once, and maybe she just sent it directly to one person who gave it to the cops, and only a handful of people have seen how pathetic she is.

Something touches her leg, and everything glitches for a moment before she sees Melog leaning on her. She closes the browser, closes the laptop lid. She slides onto the floor and runs her hand over Melog's head. It's like the bin in the decompression room in elementary school, full of rice or beans or sand depending on the week. Their fur drifts gentle across her skin and makes the crawling slow down.

Seneschal texted twenty minutes ago to see if she can cover his early shift, presumably because he realized that he's still going to be

blitzed by then. Adora said they'd finish their conversation later, and she's probably still mad about Catra suggesting that Glimmer's mom was into kids, and Catra doesn't want to be here when Adora finally realizes that she's had enough. Catra agrees to cover and texts the morning manager to confirm.

She doesn't need to leave for over an hour, but she can't go back to sleep. Melog burrows in next to her, and the ever-present hum of cars outside is finally quiet enough to hear Adora's small snores from the bedroom, and Catra knows how to hold onto a good moment for when she needs it later.

When Adora's alarm goes off at 5:30, Catra's already gone. Adora panics until she finds the roll of money in the closet and her birth certificate in the shoebox next to Adora's. Catra's text says that she had an early shift. Adora can't blame her for trying to get away from her, even just for the day. Bow texted too, asking her to call when she got a chance. Darla said that she was off work for the rest of the week, and that they'd talk about it again at her regularly scheduled session time.

Her run's shorter than usual. She keeps slowing down, fatigue pressing her down, and the thick humidity makes it harder to suck air into her lungs. Bow likes to get to the archery range before going into UNA, so she calls after eggs and a shower. He asks if she's free for lunch. "If you want," he says. "If you and Catra have other plans-"

"She's at work." Adora can't stay in this apartment until Catra's shift ends this afternoon. Darla had her make a list of activities she can do while she's home, but it's already so empty in here. Catra's never chosen to sleep apart from her before. Things aren't likely to be less stressful once she's home.

Bow's quiet for a moment. "I can ask if you can come to the of fice, if you want. We're all on paperwork for now. I'm sure Angella would let you be here if you don't want to be alone."

Adora doesn't want to see her desk, right now, but she thinks about sitting in the kitchen with the sudoku book Catra said was too easy for her or the coloring pages of scapular movement that she and Darla put on the list, with light in the windows and someone typing outside. "If that's okay ," she says.

Bow's car is tidy enough - on the spectrum of Adora's strict order and the disaster zone Glimmer prefers to live in, Bow's closer to Adora than most people. It's always brimming with archery stuf f, though. There are two plastic cases, recurve and compound, and matching quivers in the backseat. This time there's also a box of books that Adora has to move to get in. "Sorry ," Bow says with a wince. "They're for my dads, we're having dinner tonight."

Adora settles her bag at her feet. Bow seems awkward, stiff, but that's probably because he has to see his dads later. "Everything okay?"

"They're fine. I'm, uh." Bow's blinker is loud in the silence. He made the rule that neither of them are allowed to tell each other that they're fine anymore. He shrugs. "As good as any of us, I guess. How are you?"

Adora knew he would ask, and she still doesn't have an honest answer. "Holding up," she says. "Thanks for getting me."

"And Catra? She doing okay?"

By the way Bow asks, tentative, on the edge of something - he knows. Adora shouldn't be relieved that more people know. "Did Angella tell you?"

"She wouldn't've. It was - I guessed. Glimmer was there with you two and she was really upset after you went home, and she brought the

body shield when she left early. And you never went into it, but it was obvious that your foster parent was kind of a nightmare, and Catra ran away, and, you know."W as it obvious?Maybe the truth of it's been right in front of her and Adora just chose not to see it, like everything else. Bow watches the red light, probably so he doesn't have to look at her and how much she ignored. t was the only thing that made sense."

When Angella interviewed her for the job, she asked if she knew anyone who'd been sexually abused. t's really dif ficult for anyone to do this,"she said, "but especially for survivors and their loved ones. t's something we should be aware of, so we can be mindful."That's why the system was programmed to make sure Glimmer didn't get any boys in their early teens, like her dad.

"I didn't lie to Angella,"Adora says. "I never - and Catra didn't tell me."Her fingers tingle, feeling slick, and she wants to throw up. "She doesn't tell me anything."

"W e know you wouldn't do this job if you'd known. I was going to stay part-time once school started again, thought it would look good on grad school applications, but I'm honestly not sure I can stay ." They're moving again, pulling down the last block before the of fice park. "I don't know how Glimmer and Angella do it. Maybe it's different since he's gone."

Maybe that was why. Micah was an advocate, too. He talked about it in interviews about UNA, how his teacher saw someone vulnerable and drew him in, how adults in his life didn't think he needed help. Adora knows what Micah survived because he told his story. Catra never agreed to that.

"Ready?"Bow asks. "I'm early , we've got five more minutes if you want to wait."

Adora doesn't want to wait. Bow steers her away from her cubicle when they go in, which she's grateful for . Bow grabs a donut out of

the box in the kitchen and Adora puts one on a napkin that they both know she won't eat. "I'll be at my desk," he says.

Adora's anatomy coloring book is crisp and she sharpens all of her pencils before she starts. Until she got to college, she'd only ever colored in the decompression room, when that was Catra's activity and Adora was trying to help her calm down. Adora had always hated how difficult it was with school crayons, but she was in college now and if she focuses on the lines of the muscles and nerves, it's easier to ignore where her pencil slips over a line. If she focuses, she can keep her brain away from everything else. It doesn't really work and she has to keep pushing away the thoughts that keep spilling in, all the pieces she never put together.

Someone knocks on the open door, like it's her office. "It's good to see you," Angella says. "Can I sit with you a moment?"

"Of course." Adora mostly sounds normal. Her hand had stopped coloring at some point, light blue pencil trailing off towards the edge of the page when she got caught up in thinking again.

Angella pulls up the seat next to her. "The donuts are excellent. Glimmer got them from the new shop on Elberon."

Adora can't do small talk, not now. "You want to talk to me about yesterday."

"Yes." Angella folds her hands on the table. "I want to apologize. You should never have been exposed to material about someone you knew. That's not something anyone should be expected to deal with. I need to change our workflow to prevent anything like this happening again."

Adora lays the pencil down on the table before the sharp tip breaks. Her stomach aches. She doesn't know why she came here.

"It goes without saying that you'll be paid for your regular hours, as this is a work-related injury. We'll cover as many sessions with your

therapist as necessary, and please remind Catra that our therapy scheme covers partners as well. Please let us know how UNA can support the both of you right now."

Adora thinks about how Catra had sounded when she said *help me get rid of it.* "Was she in the database already?"

Angella sighs. "You're on medical leave. Strictly speaking you shouldn't even be in the building, but Bow said you would be alone at home."

Yes, because Adora had gotten a glimpse of what her girlfriend had lived through and she was the one who was benched. "She wants to know what's going to happen."

Angella folds her lips over her teeth when she thinks, like Glimmer does. Adora doesn't want to know what behaviors she shares with Weaver, other than the obvious. "Her file's already been sent to the state," Angella says quietly. "With her name. I've taken responsibility for the identification. She's quite distinctive, Adora."

That's what everyone had said, when Adora showed around missing persons flyers. They said they'd remember those eyes.

"It was our foster mother. The perpetrator." It's a word she uses all the time but it makes something flip in her gut. "Stella Weaver, she - she was-" Adora swallows hard. She talks about this shit for a living. Darla's working on getting her to say it about Weaver too. After yesterday, *abusive* should feel like an understatement. "Pretty bad."

Angella says she'll add the name to the file. Adora's question sits like a black hole in her stomach. "It wasn't just once, was it?"

More weight settles in around Angella's eyes. "I think that's a conversation you'll need to have with Catra."

Adora had known the answer. It didn't stop the chill from deepening under her ribs. "She won't talk to me."

t's dif ficult."Angella's folded hands twitch. t took a long time for Micah to get to the place he did, and he had a lot of support. t doesn't happen overnight."

Adora wants to say that Catra has support. She doesn't know how much it counts if the support has traumatized her too. Adora's going to be sick if she doesn't stop thinking about it. "I don't know what happens, after it goes back to the police."

"They'll be looking into it on their end. t hasn't even been twenty-four hours, but I think the justice department will be contacting you both soon."

Their elementary school had a behavior team and a room for kids to de-escalate, but their middle school had a counselor who Adora didn't know existed until halfway through sixth grade and a resource officer. The week after Catra's mom overdosed, she lost it on Inez Castillo in the hallway and got put in cuffs until Weaver came to pick her up. Adora could hear her screaming from her locker in the next wing. Her wrists were mottled green days later when she left the basement. "She isn't going to talk to the police."

Angella says they have to investigate anyway, that it doesn't matter if she cooperates or not. Adora tries to imagine police showing up at Weaver's house, reading out her rights, cuffing her hands. She should want that. She should want worse than that.

"Adora," Angela says, and that's when Adora hears her phone ringing.

t's Catra's manager , saying that she needs to come get her. "She's pretty messed up, I think she's on something," he says, and Adora can't make sense of that, because Catra won't even take ibuprofen since her mother died. The only reason Adora can imagine for her to start taking drugs now is if she thinks they'll kill her , and Adora knows the statistics but not Catra, not today.

I have to go," she tells Angella. When Angella reminds her to let Catra know how she can help, Adora lies like she was born to do it.

Chapter 4

The first time they tried to have oral sex, the first week after moving in together, Adora had to tug Catra back, giggling. "You're allowed to move your tongue, you know," she said. "Do you want me to go first?"

Catra blinked. For a moment, she wasn't sure where her arms were, and then she felt Adora's solid thighs under them. "I can do it," she said. She sounded far away.

She was so glad Adora thought she'd never done this, because she felt hopelessly lost. She probed, feeling around with her tongue. It was a little numb, and maybe that's why she could barely feel anything, couldn't taste anything. When she remembered how it should taste a chill flooded her chest and Adora was going to notice when her breath started to condense in front of her.

She blinked again, trying to focus, and the frustration was nearly overwhelming. Catra almost wanted to ask Adora to just climb on her, press her down, scrape along her face, do something Catra knew how to do for once, but Adora didn't like to touch Catra like that. Catra would've probably blacked out anyway, and she wanted to be able to do it right for her. She tried to remember the way Adora liked Catra to touch her with her hand, because she'd probably still want the same movements, but she couldn't translate it to a new part of her body and she fumbled.

You aren't a good enough whore for them to keep around, Weaver had said, when she was telling Catra what would happen to her on the street if she tried to run away. *You're barely good enough for me to keep around.* Awareness slipped away from her, coming in and out like a tide. She kept almost reaching up to check her head.

"Here," Adora said, guiding her away. "It's okay. Can I show you?"

Adora said it was fine that she didn't know what she was doing. Catra watched Adora's movements closely, trying to ignore how her spine buzzed. Adora kissed, sucked, drew her tongue along Catra's skin. She saw it more than felt it. She kept dropping senses, dropping minutes. This shouldn't be happening. She missed a lot, at the end, but she couldn't imagine Weaver ever doing this, when everything about Catra was so gross that she could barely stand touching her as much as she had. She liked using Catra on her, she liked carving into her as deep as she could until Catra knew she could never get her out. There would be no reason for Weaver to work her lips on her like Adora was, forehead tight with focus.

Adora was different. Adora wanted this, wanted *her*, and Catra needed to stop comparing her to the woman that made Adora act like she had to earn anything she wanted.

"You okay?" Adora asked. Catra's muscles were tensed, but so were Weaver's until she was done, so she was supposed to be. She nodded. Adora put her mouth back, and she could hear it awful and wet against her ears, and it hurt. It hurt and she couldn't move and she couldn't make a sound or she'd die.

She snapped back to Adora nestled warm alongside her. Catra's chest was heaving because her body had done something without her, proving how much she was made for this. Adora laughed a little. "You're never this relaxed," she said. Catra didn't remember being relaxed. She didn't remember a lot of things. "So you liked it?"

Catra was too slack to move, still. She tried to gather herself back together, at least in her head. Weaver had never made her pretend to be normal, after going this empty. "Clearly," she said, and she sounded blurry.

Adora kissed her mouth before settling her head on Catra's shoulder. Normally kissing Adora back wasn't hard, but Catra glitched at it now, so at least it was quick. "Don't worry about me tonight," Adora said. "That was amazing. You're so amazing. I don't know how you

stay so qiet, it's - you know how bad Iam at that. Ilove it, Ilove you."

Catra didn't know what she meant, but Adora was still here so she didn't care. One of her arms was starting to respond, and she looped it around Adora's back. "Ilove you."She didn't know how long it would take her brain to start working again, after this.

Adora giggled again, and Catra would do anything to keep her sounding like that. "W ow. Think Ibroke you,"she said. Catra should have told her that she was already broken in all the ways that matter, but she needed Adora to stay where she was, so she didn't.

They moved here together almost three months ago and Adora still nearly forgot to bring the laundry card when she left. Adora ran a load through the wash mostly for the excuse to be out of the apartment. She didn't have to pretend she wasn't furious in the deserted laundry room. f she went back up right now , she was going to start snapping again and she never knew if Catra was going to yell back or go still like Adora had a knife to her throat, and Adora didn't really have the patience for either one right now.

Adora knew, academically, that it wasn't Catra's fault that she couldn't handle anyone being angry . Adora couldn't handle it herself, most of the time. But it didn't help when Adora was already upset, especially when Catra acted like Adora raising her voice at all was the eqivalent of pulling a gun on her . "Fix your face,"W eaver used to tell Adora, when her heart had pounded out of her chest and she'd been so scared she was going to die. "Y ou make me feel like a terrible mother when you get so dramatic."Adora knew that wasn't okay, now, but she hated that she understood what Weaver had meant.

The beginning of field hockey season had been hell. Coach Hope said that the board was talking about cutting scholarships if they didn't make it to at least regional finals, and Adora was running drills longer and longer every week. Her shoes were shot through and Coach Hope said she was going to be benched before she sprained something if she didn't have new ones by tomorrow. The store was holding them for her across town, and Catra had the car to get to work, and all she'd asked Catra to do was pick them up while Adora had been on campus all day. Adora should have guessed that Catra couldn't handle it.

She couldn't stall down here forever. When she thought she could keep her voice at a normal volume, at least until Catra needled her again, she went back up the stairs. Catra was shredding junk mail on the couch, making a mess of scattered paper around her, and Adora was going to hold on to the calm she had.

"Now I wish I did get them so I could burn the damn things," Catra said, almost under her breath, but she knew Adora could hear her.

Adora was trying, but Coach was probably going to make her sit out of practice tomorrow, and she'd have to take three buses to get to the store, and she'd miss her first two classes and her GPA would drop again and she'd lose her scholarship and end up working for minimum wage like every other former foster kid she'd ever met. "It would've taken five minutes," Adora said, frustration bubbling again. "This should not have been a big deal."

"Yeah, you're perfect and I'm a fuckup, you've made that clear." Catra's pieces of paper kept getting smaller, and Catra always cleaned up after she did this but they didn't have a vacuum so she never got them all. Adora was going to be finding tiny scraps in random places for the next week.

Adora had homework to do and she had nowhere to work but the table, but Catra was still making a disaster zone of the couch and Adora couldn't focus on a damn thing with the tension filling up every

inch of the room. "Can I go to bed," Adora said, even though it was barely nine, "or is moving the laundry too much to ask?"

Catra picked up another sheet of coupons they couldn't afford to spend. "I don't know, are those t-shirts vitally important to your life? I need to make sure I screw it up as thoroughly as possible."

Everything Adora had been losing her mind to do was for Catra. Adora hadn't had to share the car, she'd had a room and meal plan covered by her scholarship. She gave that up so Catra could get off Scorpia's couch and be here with her, and Adora didn't even remember now why that had felt so important. "You don't care," she said. "I'm working so hard and you don't care at all."

"Poor you." The sound of the paper tearing grated on Adora's final nerve. "Working *so hard*, your girlfriend's so ungrateful, will *anyone* grovel in front of Saint Ad-"

All of the tension in Adora's chest exploded out at once. "Oh my god, shut up!"

Catra's shoulders stiffened, and her ripping hands went still, and for a moment Adora was even angrier, because she wasn't Weaver and it wasn't fair for Catra to act like she was going to hurt her when she knew she wouldn't. *You're so manipulative,* a voice said in her head, and usually Weaver had meant Adora when she said that but Adora felt manipulated, right now. Catra screwed her face up tight and punched the sofa hard, and Adora jumped but Catra didn't even notice and Adora didn't want to be here anymore.

It's a good thing Glimmer was on her speed dial. "Hey," Adora said. She looked away from Catra, but Catra's harsh breathing was loud enough for her to hear. "Is your suite's couch free?"

Glimmer said she'd be waiting to swipe her into her dorm. Adora didn't bother turning on the bedroom light. The open door let in enough light to find a change of clothes for her gym bag. When she

turned back there was a silhouette in the doorway. "Make it quick," Adora said, heart still going too fast.

"I'm sorry," Catra said, all in a rush. "I shouldn't have messed up. I should have listened better and I wouldn't've forgot." She sounded like Adora felt when she got crushed down under the weight of whatever she'd done wrong, voice on the edge of frantic. "I- I shouldn't have talked to you like that either. I shouldn't have hit something. I know that's not okay, I know you don't like it. I'm sorry."

Adora's bag felt heavier on her shoulder. "I'm still really pissed."

"I know. It was important." Adora couldn't really see her, in the shadows stretching from the doorway, but it was obvious that Catra was upset, that she felt guilty. "I'll do better next time."

Adora sighed, and she couldn't be mad at Catra when she was like this, raw and trying. "Thank you," she said. "I really - I'm mad because my tomorrow's fucked now, and you can't fix that, but it's extra hard when you're an asshole about it."

"I'm sorry," Catra said again. Her fingers brushed Adora's sides, too light, like she wasn't sure if she could.

Adora found her shoulders in the dim light, ran her palms down her arms firm. She just wanted the fight to be over, wanted to keep this Catra that cared about her. "It's okay," she said, even though it wasn't really.

They kissed, and after Catra pushed her back on the bed Adora didn't care about tomorrow anymore. They'd done this enough times that Catra mostly knew what to do with her mouth, now, knowing where and how to tip Adora over. When Adora snapped back, Catra kissed her on the head and left to move the wash to the dryer. Adora texted Glimmer that she'd see her tomorrow.

The next morning, when Adora was leaving practice to catch the bus, Catra was there. "Sorry they're late," she said, shoving a

shoebox in Adora's hands. "Store didn't open until eight."

The dread that built while she sat and watched practice happen without her, thinking about how Coach was going to replace her and she was going to lose everything - it all evaporated. Adora held the box and felt warm, happy, safe. "Thank you," she said, and Catra's mismatched eyes lit up when she smiled. Her double shift ran until Adora was asleep that night, and the clothes that Adora had almost forgotten about were missing from her gym bag by the next morning.

They'd been dating for almost eleven months. BMU finished the opening round game against Plumeria 4-3 in overtime, and the bleachers shook with how loud the crowd screamed when Adora scored. Glimmer and Bow jumped up, arms pumping, and Catra couldn't tear her eyes away from Adora on the field. She was chasing down Mermista for a high five like she always did, golden ponytail streaming out behind her, mouth guard bright against her lips as she grinned. She nearly ran into Frosta, coming from their goal, and crashed into a hug. The crowd was pulsing with excitement together and Catra maybe got for a second why people enjoyed watching sports even if their girlfriend wasn't playing.

Later, when the post-game celebration was over and it was just the two of them, Adora was still glowing. She kissed Catra like she was trying to carry on the winning streak, arms around her back, body pressing up against hers, beautiful and strong and *happy*, and Catra would do anything to keep it this way. She barely even registered their mouths anymore, because it didn't matter, nothing mattered because Adora was here and incredible and she loved her.

Her bed hit the back of her knees and Adora lowered her down careful, and it was easy to shake the phantom feeling of carpet on her neck because Adora was heavy and everywhere. It was easier to

blink out in this position but she couldn't stop this if she wanted to. She didn't care as long as she came back to Adora kissing her , holding her. Adora never seemed to notice when she wasn't there, and she didn't mind leaving if that was what she got to return to.

Adora pulled back a little, came up on her elbows. The skin over her ribs was warm under Catra's hands. "Hey ,"she said, cheeks going red. "I've, uh. I've been reading?"

Catra tilted her forehead against Adora's neck. "Dangerous."She pulled a little on Adora's waist and Adora followed, hair flopping on the mattress next to her.

"I- can we try something?I know you said you're - you're happy , with what we're already doing."Her breath was soft on the side of Catra's face. "But I- I think you'll like it."

"Y ou don't need to sell me,"she said. Adora could ask her to jump on a sword and she'd do it. "I trust you."

Adora hummed and Catra could feel it in her bones. Adora kissed her again, one hand coming up to her hair, stroking her scalp, and it's like she didn't feel or care about the scars snaking through it where scissors had caught skin. Catra shoved the thought away hard. She loved Adora. t shouldn't be this hard not to think about someone else. Adora's other hand slipped under her shirt, cupped her breast, and she knew it wasn't Adora wrenching and tearing but it didn't make it hurt any less.

She flickered back when Adora's lips pressed on her neck. They had fewer clothes than she remembered. "God, the way you just *melt,*" Adora said, voice soft, pleased. "I love you so much."

"I love you too,"she said, and her eyes prickled. She pressed her tongue against her teeth. Adora was still over her like a blanket, like a shield. She needed to try to remember this for when she couldn't have it anymore, when Adora realized there wasn't anything here to love.

Adora came up to kiss her mouth again, lips soft and tongue seeking. Catra tried to echo it back, but she was clumsy and numb. She found Adora's shoulder and held on like it was keeping her from tumbling over a cliff. Adora's skin was taut over the muscles. She could probably tell Catra which muscles shifted under her fingers. She reached down with her other hand to help Adora before Catra lost too much movement to do it, but Adora guided her back. "Going to show you first," Adora said, and Catra managed to nod. She forgot. Usually she didn't have to think much when she was fading.

Adora's hand slipped lower, and she only knew where it was because she stopped feeling Adora's hand at all. Her heartbeat picked up in her ears, the way it was supposed to. They'd done this so many times. Adora said something that was too far away for Catra to hear, and stilled. Adora didn't move again until Catra tugged hard enough on her puppet strings to make what might be a nod.

Adora's finger was cool and slick when it slipped into her, and she must have been glitching again because Adora moved slow but something scraped, ripped with long claws, tore her open to pull her out. Adora liked when she was quiet for sex but she wasn't being quiet, she could hear how not-quiet she was, a moan that wasn't the kind Adora wanted, loud with nothing over her mouth to block it. She was an oozing pile of sludge, rot seeping out onto Adora's hands, smearing them with blood.

"Hey," Adora said. She didn't sound right. She was lying next to her now, pulling the blanket to cover them, arm over her shoulders, foot hooked behind her ankle. Adora's chest rose too fast under her cheek. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to. I'm so sorry."

Catra couldn't control her body for a while. She didn't want to, now. She wanted to stay where she could hear Adora's heart beat in her ear, where it didn't matter if she was a person or not, where she could pretend that she lived somewhere better than her own bones. Anything was worth it for this.

When she got enough of herself working to hug Adora back, Adora pulled back to look at her. Her eyes were wide and scared in the fading light. "What happened?"

"Sorry ," Catra said. Her brain still skittered a little, thoughts hard to pin down. She wasn't entirely sure what Adora was talking about. Normally they could just lie there together for a while before she had to say anything. She pressed her hands on Adora's back to try to pull her closer but this time she didn't follow .

"*I'm* sorry. I hurt you." Adora wiped at her face, and that was when Catra registered the wetness in her hair. Her other arm stayed behind Catra's neck, holding her shoulder . "I don't - I don't know how that happened. I'm so sorry . I tried to be careful. I didn't want to hurt you and I did anyway ."

Catra found the I'm-fine smile, kissed Adora's scrunched face. "It was just intense," she said. When Adora frowned at her , she added, "Not bad, uh, overwhelming. Maybe I'm just not ready for it yet."

Adora pulled her in tight. "It's okay ." Adora held her like she thought she could keep her together with enough pressure, and maybe she could. "There's a thousand other things, if you want."

Cara swallowed. Next time she'd have to figure out how to be quiet. Maybe if Adora was kissing her when she did it, maybe if Catra bit something. "Next ti-"

"No," Adora said. Her rib cage stuttered rough. "Not that. W ell - I'll find something else." Guilt kept pushing her down and Catra could never help when she got this way. She'd been so happy , and she'd wanted this, and Catra ruined it like she ruins everything.

Catra pressed her face into Adora's chest. She wasn't a good person, because she kept breaking Adora apart, but she didn't know how to stop. She thought about Adora finding someone better, someone who could fuck her the way she wanted without turning into roadkill that hadn't finished dying, and she wondered if Adora would

sqeez out the life she has left before she moved on, if Catra asked.

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t had been a year since theyd admitted that *I love you* meant something else, and Adora didnt know what to do. She thought Catra liked her, most of the time, but kissing didnt go anywhere anymore. After Adora messed up, she didnt let her hands trail to places they wouldnt have been welcome before they started dating and Catra didnt seem to care, like Adora had ruined sex so badly that she didnt even want it, at least not with Adora. Catra still clung to her in their bed all night, curled into her on the couch when they talked about their days, held her face while they kissed like she couldnt be too close, but it was obvious that Adora wasnt good enough.

t wasnt new . Shed always known she was awkward, stupid, too bulbous too calloused too misshapen for Catra to actually be attracted to. Maybe Adora was just convenient. Maybe that was why Catra got distracted during sex sometimes, eyes getting distant and movements clumsy, because she was thinking about someone she actually wanted.

Adora had tried to make up for it. Weaver had never signed the permission slip for that part of health class, not that Adora thought Hayes would have taught anything relevant to them anyway. All Adora had known was the way shed figured out how to get herself off when she was thirteen and frustrated alone in her bed, and the way Huntara had eaten her out after the UCW game when Adora was too worked up to really pay attention, and of course Adora hadnt known enough about sex to actually keep Catra interested in her.

When she'd researched she found the basic thing she should have been doing the whole time. She'd tried groping inside herself while Catra was working late, and it had lit her up, and she'd thought that maybe Catra wouldn't give up on her if she could make her feel this too. After the game, when she was dizzy from senses full of Catra and victory-drunk, she'd felt like maybe she could be enough this time. But she'd messed it up, like she messes up everything - her fingernails caught or she moved too fast or she didn't use enough lube or *something*. She shouldn't have assumed that Catra's body would work the same way hers had, and all Catra's reassurances sounded hollow because Adora had made her seize up and cry out like she'd been stabbed.

So she deserved this. It had been a year today since they kissed the first time, and Catra had left early this morning, and Adora had come alone in the shower last night because she couldn't stop thinking about something her girlfriend didn't even want anymore. When her phone buzzed while she was at lunch on campus with Glimmer , it wasn't Catra because she didn't love Adora the way Adora loved her and maybe she never had.

"What's going on?" Glimmer asked. Adora must not have controlled her face fast enough.

Adora shook her head. She shoved her phone in her bag like it would help her forget about it and started to fish the tomatoes out of the sandwich Glimmer had insisted on paying for. They were too slick and slippery to tolerate when her skin was itchy already.

Glimmer said, "You know I'm going to figure it out. And I'm going to tattle to your girlfriend that you're throwing vegetables away."

"She doesn't want to date me anymore," Adora said, and she dropped the tomato on her plate because suddenly she couldn't even stand to touch it. Maybe she would just toss this whole thing, money down the drain, because she was ungrateful incompetent *awful* and she didn't deserve to fix the ache in her stomach.

Look at me," Glimmer said. She talked Adora through breathing slower, feeling her feet on the ground, finding something she can see in every color. When Adora's heart beat closer to normal, Glimmer said, "You didn't tell me Catra broke up with you. When? Do you need me to yell at her? Please let me yell at-"

"We didn't break up yet." Adora knew it couldn't really be this cold in the student union, even in January. Her sweatshirt might as well be paper.

"Then what are you talking about?"

"She's going to. I know she's going to. She doesn't - she doesn't want-" Adora couldn't talk about this, not to Glimmer and especially not at a table in the middle of the Commons. Glimmer talked about sex sometimes, tone casual until Adora teased her about Bow and Glimmer's face went as flushed as Adora felt. Glimmer was going to want to talk about this, and Adora didn't get to talk about what had happened when she wasn't the one who got hurt. "She doesn't want me anymore."

Glimmer scrubbed a hand on her face. "I am going to drag you kicking and screaming to therapy," she says. "Catra's so intense about you it would concern me if you weren't just as bad. Last semester she had your practice schedule memorized down to the minute. If she didn't tell you she's breaking up with you, I guarantee you she isn't."

Catra had always been waiting to drive her home after practice on the days she didn't have a work shift. She'd scheduled all of her hours around Adora's games, even when it meant she worked doubles two days in a row. Adora was being a selfish idiot. "We first kissed a year ago," she said, because she knew Glimmer was going to make fun of her for being upset about nothing.

"Let me guess, Catra didn't say anything and that's why you're convinced that she hates you now?"

t did sound even dumber when Glimmer said it. Adora pulled of f pieces of her sandwich bread. "I didn't expect her to care," she said, even though if the Catra of last semester remembered when Adora got out of practice she'd think she'd remember this. "I don't want to be *that* girlfriend."

Glimmer picked up her phone, typed, put it down. "Y ou are, kinda, but only because you definitely didn't tell her you wanted things to be special today."

"It's silly ." Adora put bread in her mouth so she didn't have to say anything else and it just sat there, dry and tasteless. This wasn't a problem, Catra not touching her like that anymore wasn't a problem, Adora needed to stop being so ridiculous. She'd never appreciated what she had.

Glimmer's mouth twisted a little. "It's not silly to want to celebrate things like that." Her hair swung when she leaned on her elbow . "Bow's dads do anniversaries for their first date and they're married, you're allowed to care about it. t *is* kind of silly to think that Catra doesn't love you anymore because she can't read your mind."

Adora had to swallow hard to get the bread down. When she changed the subject, Glimmer let her . When she left statistics, Catra was outside in the car even though she'd worked an early shift and she should probably have been catching up on sleep. "Hey Adora," she said, smiling the way that made Adora feel insane, and she didn't need flowers or cards or sex if her girlfriend was willing to keep smiling at her like that.

They went home, and when they kissed Adora pulled her hand from the edge of Catra's bra like it had burned her . Catra's shoulders tensed and she said, "I'm sorry . I was trying to give you space but - I know I ruined it, before, I didn't want to. T ell me how to fix it." Adora tried to say that it was her fault, but Catra kissed her deep, and this time it did keep going the way Adora wanted it to, and maybe she didn't break this. Catra went boneless at her touch, the way she only

did for Adora, and maybe Catra meant it when she said she loved her.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra gets to the store way too early, but that's fine. Rogelio's coming in for the bakery and he waves when he sees her. She waves back and plays logic puzzles on her phone until it's time to clock in.

She likes her job, most days. She's busy, restocking areas that had gone sparse the evening before, cataloging what came in on the truck and what she needs to tell the manager to request, putting back the things that customers have misplaced. She's been here a little over a year, which makes her one of the more senior employees, and she knows every inch of the store and where everything goes inside it. She doesn't talk to customers unless she absolutely has to, but the other employees ask her where certain stock is, and it's satisfying to be an expert at something. Entrapta's on this shift too, working the back, and Catra's happy to see her because she won't ask about Catra's family emergency yesterday. Like always, she wants to talk about the computers she's building, and Catra likes to listen to her talk even when she doesn't understand it all.

She's unloading fruit cans in 9b a few hours later. Down the aisle, a family argues about applesauce pouches, because the younger kid wants the strawberry kind and won't stop whining about it. "I told you no," the mother snaps at the kid. "Shut up before you make us late."

Catra drops a can of pineapple. The older kid picks it up, because it rolled two feet before Catra was able to move again, and slides it on the shelf where she's stocking. He's probably five? Six? Seven? Catra doesn't know, and it's suddenly vitally important to know, like if

he's young enough she can still save him, but she can't speak yet. His family's cart is at the end of the aisle and he disappears after it.

Catra forces air into her lungs and finishes unloading the case. Every time someone comes down her aisle, her heartbeat picks up, and it's just like being in school again, except this isn't supposed to happen anymore. She's in Bright Moon, hours away, and has been for over a year. She hears those words all the time. She can't turn into that person again, jumping at every shadow.

She switches sections with Molly. Produce is open, wide, and there's plenty to do there. Molly's awkwardly standing behind the cheese counter not far away. She's fine. It's getting busier, and she's cleaning up a container of spinach that fell apart all over the floor and the display, and people keep staring at her. She can't see them when she looks up, but she can feel eyes on her whenever she looks back at the leaves on the floor. They're all staring, peeling her with their eyes, trying to decide who should go first.

They've seen it, all the seconds Catra remembers and all the ones she doesn't, because if Weaver could film them once she could have done it every time, and while Catra's brain cuts out sometimes, a camera watches everything. Everyone knows just what she is, what she's always been. They know what they can do to her.

Someone laughs, how Weaver laughed under her breath when Catra was being scared in a funny way, and there's a hand in her hair pushing her to the ground. Weaver's hands are tight on her throat, knee grinding up to press against her where she already hurts and she can't get enough air to cry about it and the meat that she lives in bends to whatever Weaver wants.

"Hey, uh, Catra?"

She's crouched on the floor, holding a brush and a dustpan of spinach, and Molly shifts from foot to foot in front of her. Her face is cold. She still feels hands on her neck but she can't see them. "You okay?" she asks.

She wants to tell him to go do his damn job. If she opens her mouth Weaver's going to climb inside. If she moves she'll die. Her throat hurts.

"I'm gonna - I'm gonna get Sean, okay?"

She wants to tell him to stay. He's incompetent, but he must not know what she is or he wouldn't be talking to her. He'd probably get help if Weaver came back. She's tucked against the edge of the display, and Weaver used to reach under the bed to get her with arms that were too long and spidery to be real. Nothing would stop her here.

Someone is talking, arm on her shoulder. When she starts to melt it's only the display that keeps her from lying in the pile of spilled spinach. Somebody says *9 .1* If Catra goes to the hospital again she'll be in the basement until flies lay eggs in her corpse.

"Alright," a voice that isn't Weaver's says. "Let's get you to the back so we can figure this out, okay?"

Someone hauls her up and she manages to stay quiet. She isn't good at walking. A voice asks if she's having a stroke, and another says she's probably on drugs. She just wants the hands to tighten and finish her already.

She's sitting in the staff room. She can see her manager now. Weaver's gone. Sean's talking to him about her, like her body's empty. "I don't know what happened," he's saying. "She was cleaning and she just started crying."

Sean looks back at Catra. Snaps his fingers in her face. "You on something?"

She shakes her head. Maybe she'd feel better if she was. Maybe this happened to her mom too and that's why she took so much that her body gave up. Catra would take any poison right now if someone said it would make this stop.

"We called your emergency contact," Sean says. "She's coming to get you." Catra will be okay, if Adora's coming.

Catra's starting to come back to life, arms moving to fold across her chest, when Adora gets there. "Can you walk?" Adora asks, and Catra nods before she tries to stand and slithers towards the ground until Adora catches her. Sean tells Adora they have to do a drug test tomorrow. "She doesn't take drugs," Adora says, but she looks at Catra when she says it, and Catra knows her well enough to see when gears turn in her brain. Sean says it's the policy. Adora says she'll be there.

It's raining, when they leave the store, and so Catra can justify holding onto Adora past the point where she needs her to not fall over.

Catra's mostly walking by herself by the time they get to the car, but Adora's still too jittery to let go of her before she has to. She's moving odd, too slow, clumsy. Catra doesn't say anything in the store, the whole walk out, even once they're in the car. She looks straight ahead, eyes half-lidded, head down. Adora doesn't even know anything about drugs beyond some of the names, beyond the brief rants Bonnie used to give after Weaver called her a crack baby. *Mom did heroin*, she'd say. *She shouldn't open her mouth if she don't know the difference.*

Catra's mother overdosed when they were eleven, and Adora has to assume that's why she won't take pain medicine for anything. Mara took something to die too, when Adora was four months old, and she doesn't know what it was that killed her. She has no idea if Catra could get ahold of it. She pulls up directions for the ER on her phone and her hands shake so bad she wonders if she should just call an

ambulance before she crashes, but Catra doesn't have insurance, but-

"Not high," Catra mutters in the seat next to her. She's still not looking at Adora. "Not drunk either."

"We're still-"

Catra pulls Adora's phone out of her hand, fingers fumbling a little, and that's not Catra. She's sharp and precise in a way that Adora will never be, manipulating tiny paper folds to make something intricate that Adora's hands are too big and dumb to manage. "Hospital isn't going to fix me," she says.

Adora doesn't want to do anything Catra doesn't want anymore. She's done plenty of that. She also doesn't want Catra to die because Adora let herself ignore a problem again. "Something could be wrong in your *brain*," Adora says, reaching to take her phone back.

Catra holds Adora's phone tight, fingers paling on the white-and-gold case. "She broke me, okay?" Her face spasms before going back to too-still. "Now this just happens sometimes."

"You're not broken," Adora says automatically, while she processes that. Adora had an online training about trauma when she started at UNA, about how fear responses look different in different people, about fight or flight or freeze or flop. She'd seen how sometimes people got too still, or slumped like they were asleep. Adora thought she knew a trauma response when she saw it. She didn't know what it meant, when they were kids and Catra froze up, when *Adora* froze up because she was too stupid to realize that her parent shouldn't scare her. The training said going limp made an assault hurt less. Adora stops thinking about that so she doesn't throw up in the parking lot where Catra works.

"Is she here?" Adora makes herself ask. Catra shakes her head, and the clamp around her lungs loosens a little. "Then what happened?"

"Fucking nothing." Catra throws Adora's phone into the footwell and puts her hands on her elbows, kicks her knees up on the glove compartment so she can slide down in the seat. "What about broken' was confusing?"

"You're not-"

"I forgot you were the expert." Catra ducks her head away, shoulders twitching. Her hair's getting longer all the time, and it's nearly to her neck now. It felt like a way to track progress once, but they've taken so many steps back, and maybe only Adora had even thought they were moving forward at all.

It takes every ounce of self-control Adora has not to ask *why didn't you tell me.* "Science says it's an instinct," she says instead. "The body trying to protect itself."

"Then it's a dumb piece of shit," Catra snaps. Her eyes look clearer every minute. "Didn't fucking do that at all."

"You made it," Adora says. "You - you sur-"

"She liked it." Catra's face twists, voice all restrained fury, leg tensing against the glove compartment. She hasn't looked directly at Adora since they were in the staff room. Adora doesn't know if she's grateful for that or not. "Convenient feature to have in a - something that can just stop working and *take it*."

The facts feel disconnected. Adora's supposed to know a trauma response when she sees one. Catra goes limp when she's triggered. Weaver abused her. When they have sex Catra melts out, and Adora used to like that too, used to think it was proof that she was making Catra happy. There's some awful conclusion that Adora knows is there, *knows* is right, but if she looks directly at it she's going to get burned, it's going to consume her, so she can't. She turned her ankle bad in the regional semifinal last year, and she didn't know anything was wrong until she tried to stand up in Mermista's living room while

the team was celebrating that night. She's good at looking away from things that hurt until she can afford to let them.

Catra burrows deeper into the seat, expression stormy. Adora's known her long enough to know when something's churning behind her anger, and Adora doesn't want anything Catra's been saying to spend more time in her head.

"You know she was wrong, right?" When Catra flinches Adora realizes she's never said it, all these months, all these years. She doesn't remember the details of what Weaver said, now, but she knew the hatred in her voice, even compressed and digital. "You were a kid. There's no - even when you *weren't* a kid there was no making that okay. You were never any of the things she said you were, and that wouldn't have justified anything she did anyway."

Catra's foot swings hard against the glove compartment. The solid *thunk* makes Adora's breath catch. "You don't know *shit*."

"Then tell me." Adora's still ignoring the supernova, bright in her peripheral vision, but she can see enough scattered pieces of it to know that there's a good reason why Catra doesn't trust her. If Adora gets too close to the thought she won't be able to help Catra and that's the only thing that matters, right now and always.

Catra's hand clasps over the back of her neck, arm pinned along the side of her head, and it's so much like the way the kid tried to cover their head that Adora has to jerk her eyes away. Seeing Catra in distress always brings the same words to the front of her tongue - *it's okay, I'll help, I love you.* It's grossly inadequate and now she knows just how pathetic it always has been.

"How old," Catra grits out between her teeth, and Adora knows exactly what she's asking. She knew that it didn't happen once but it's still a gut punch, thinking about how much happened in front of her face, how many signs she must have decided to look away from just like she's deciding to look away now.

She swallows. The rain on the windshield casts mottled shadows on Catra's face. "I don't know." Adora can hear the tears in her voice like she's someone else. "Seven, maybe? Is that possible?"

Catra shrugs, then nods. Adora's choking in the apologies climbing up her throat, fighting to break out of her chest. Her friends and her therapist say she apologizes too much. *Everything has to be about you*, Catra had said yesterday. She doesn't want Adora to say she's sorry, a couple empty words that don't change anything. Adora needs to *do* something.

"The - when you-" *relax*, her brain finishes, and Adora turns her back to the thought, "dissociate, like now. What helps?"

Catra tilts her head back, looking up out the windshield. Her arm comes down. "Nothing. I don't know. It's not like there's been a lot of trial and error."

"We'll figure it out," Adora says, feeling better immediately now that she has a mission. "This happens to other people too, there have to be treatments or techniques or something."

Catra presses her arms over her stomach, tense. "You don't need another project, Adora."

"You're not a project," Adora says. Her hands tangle in her lap like she can pretend they're not both hers. She wants to hold Catra, to try to push how she feels across the wall between them like chemicals into a cell. When it's good it feels like there's nothing there, like they're finally the same person and Adora never has to lose her again. She can't touch her now and the knowledge of why lurks in deep shadows at the edge of her mind. "You're my girlfriend," she says. "I want you to be happy."

"You've never had a realistic goal in your life," Catra says, and she sounds more fond than frustrated. "I'm not - I can't-"

When Catra breaks off, blinking hard, Adora says, "I love you, it's going to be okay."

Catra shudders once, quick, pushing back into the seat, and reaches to pull out one of Adora's hands and Adora lets her. "Promise?"

"I promise," Adora says. Catra hangs on to her hand like it's the only thing keeping them from flying apart.

Catra isn't entirely sure how they got home. Nothing really mattered after Adora knew she was ruined and said she'd keep her anyway. They watch stupid competition shows, the kind of thing they watched together when they got home before Weaver, so they had an excuse to sit together on the couch. The fact that Adora is staying still this long is a sign that she feels as drained by the last two days as Catra does. Adora's still a little jumpy, but she doesn't push Catra away when she curls against her side on the couch. On the laptop, people blow glass, pulling shapes out of the flames glowing and fragile, and Catra knows how they feel, now that Adora sees what she is but stays. When Catra says that Jeremy should hope he drops his weird rat so he has to start over, Adora giggles, and it's like everything never happened.

Adora doesn't stop her from getting in bed next to her that night either, and Catra *needs* Adora close to her like she needs air, a sharp pang under her ribs. It's not the same as what Adora needs, but it feels just as strong as songs say that feels, for normal people. Part of her wants to move fast, to hurry past the actual sex to the part where they are wrapped up in each other and she can finally breathe for the first time in days, but Adora likes sex, even if she's too anxious to start it. Catra owes Adora something she likes, after the past two days. Adora pulls up her blanket, tension seeping out of

her forehead, and Catra kisses her the way Adora likes when she's tired and wants them to go slow, soft and light, hand on her face.

Adora makes an alarmed sqeak. She pushes hard on Catra's shoulders. "No," she says, on the edge of gasping, and the sense of safety building in Catra's chest is dashed out.

Catra is out of the bed. It's cold in her sleeveless top and shorts. Adora *lied,* she wanted Catra to think she was okay before she kicked her legs out from under her, before she laughed about how stupid Catra was to think she could have anything. She should know better by now.

"Catra," Adora says. She's sitting up, face full in the dim light coming through the windows. "Come back. W e - we have to talk."

Catra isn't so deluded she doesn't know what a breakup sounds like. She can't feel her face. She doesn't know what expression she's wearing. It doesn't matter anymore.

Adora's still saying her name, probably. She's saying something. Catra knows the backpack is on the top shelf of the closet, where she put it when Glimmer asked if she usually just left shit laying around, and Glimmer was probably fucking in on it too, her and her damn mother and Adora, ready to remind Catra exactly how little she matters. She doesn't know how she let herself forget.

Adora steps in front of her. Catra doesn't need the backpack anyway. It wasn't going to get her anywhere, there's nowhere to *go.* There's no amount of running away that will make her body somewhere she wants to live. If Adora wasn't right in her face she could get the kitchen knives, make a mess that Adora would have to get on her knees to scrub clean.

Adora grabs her shoulders and she jolts. "*Listen.* "

"Made that mistake already ," Catra says.

"If you think I'm telling you to leave, I'm not."Adora's voice is tight and tense, and she's not good enough at lying to pull it off. "I just - please stop. We have to *talk.*"

Catra knows Adora well enough to know where her weak spots are. If she wanted, she could strike them until Adora finally comes at her - *you're a failure* and *Bonnie helped me more than you ever did* and *your mother killed herself when she saw what came out of her, I don't blame her*. It's not true, and she'd be putting too many of Weaver's words in her own mouth. Instead she says, "I don't know how anyone buys your bullshit, you're fucking terrible at lying."

"Then you should know I'm not!"Adora's hands are still on her bare shoulders, calloused palms on her skin, and part of Catra keeps braced for when Adora's going to throw her back. Maybe this wasn't about Adora not wanting her after all - maybe Adora just wants her dumb and slack and scared instead, maybe when she saw Catra earlier she realized how better she is when she's all the way empty. "I love you, I want you to stay, I just - we can't do that anymore."

"Yeah, I fucking heard you."Adora's hands are the only spots of warmth in the universe. Weaver made her feel like that sometimes, on the rare occasions that she acted like she wanted Catra alive, so Catra knows she only wants Adora's hands to stay because she's broken. "I know you just washed the sheets, if you didn't want me to *dirty* them-"

"No. That's - no."Adora pulls her hands away, so she's not disagreeing with *that* part. "I still - it's your bed, our bed, if you want it to be. If you want me to sleep on the couch I'll-"

"Well you can't wash the couch after it's had something like-"

"Stop it."Adora's hands are starting to fist, so she's on her way to angry, and at least if she's angry she's probably not going to laugh at her, dig in her nails until she can't stay quiet, jam her fingers in her mouth to see if she's alive enough to bite today. Weaver was always

cold and smiling when she was cruelest. "That's not what I'm saying. You know it's not. Please don't be a jerk right now."

"What else should I be?" Catra feels crazy, poison gushing out of her like an open wound. The soreness in her stomach that never really goes away is worse than it's been in months. "If you don't want me anymore you don't get to fucking criticize me."

"I do want you, I do," Adora says, and all the anxious lines of her body show how much of a liar she is. "But it can't be like before, you don't even - I'm not going to do that to you if I know what's happening."

Catra loved so many parts of sex with Adora, the parts she was there for, the times when she could make Adora relax for once, when Adora was only focused on her and she could pretend she was someone worth existing. Maybe that's part of why Adora doesn't want to do it anymore. Adora says, "I don't know why we're fighting about this."

"You don't-" There are heavy textbooks on the shelf next to her, and Catra yanks them to thud on the floor and it doesn't help, it never helps. She should've swung them, drawn blood and bruises, and then maybe Adora would get it. "You could've asked for the refund when I told you I was in damaged condition, you didn't have to lie to me."

Adora makes a frustrated noise behind her teeth, flush raising on her cheeks, arms coming up. "I don't know how many times I have to tell you I don't want to *return you*, listen to me."

Catra's hands are tight on her own arms, digging in the nails, trying to keep from just disintegrating. "I don't know how many times I have to tell you I know what no means."

"Oh my god," Adora says, finally even a third as angry as Catra. "You can't just - *I* can't, it's not okay, even you have to know that it's not supposed to be like that."

She didn't have a chance, because apparently nothing matters until she can make herself want sex the same way Adora does, and she's already beaten her head against that wall enough. "It never bothered you before, don't pretend this is about-"

"Of course it bothered me!" Adora's bright red, hair moving loose around her face when she gestures big and furious. "I kept feeling like you were somewhere else, I knew you weren't there all the time, I thought there was something wrong with *me,* I didn't know-" *there was something wrong with you,* she doesn't have to say. Adora gasps, and her face convulses like an electric shock. She presses her hands together in front of her, shoulders flexing. "Your body was trying to protect you from me and I didn't see it and I'm sorry."

"I know I don't work right," Catra grinds out. "I already *told* you, it's not my fault if you weren't paying attention." That was her mistake, telling Adora anything she could use to hurt her.

"You're not broken," Adora says, and this is why she tells her things, because she sounds like she means it, face open and every feeling spilled on it. "I want to help you, that's what I said, right?"

Catra can feel herself starting to give, the way she always does for Adora, and for a fierce instant that's one of the things she hates about herself. She can't try any harder. If this isn't enough for Adora there isn't anything more she can do. "You're not going to fix me, there's nothing here."

"Don't say that," Adora says. She moves like she's going to run her hand on her arm, or cup her face, or pull their foreheads together like every time Adora was there for her, but Adora stops herself, because her body knows what she's too guilty to say.

"You can't even *touch* me," Catra says, and she's superheated glass again, and she's shattering while bursting into flames. Her brain offers up a spray of her own blood and bone fragments again, and it feels almost violent enough. "Cut the bullshit and just *admit it*, you

hate me, you think I'm disgusting, you want me to go where I belong on a fucking street corner-"

"*Stop,* " Adora says, way too loud, and she closes her eyes and swallows and her lip warps where she's chewing on the inside, and Catra knows what Adora trying not to cry looks like. "I don't know what she did." She sits on the floor , heavy, like she hadn't fully meant to drop. "I don't know how many times I've done the same thing as her, I can't - I can't do that anymore." Her hands go into her hair , pressing against her head. Catra almost can't look at her face, wrenching shut, looking as alone as Catra feels.

The rage dies like a fire in a storm. This happens a lot - she gets swept up in it, huge and consuming, and it vanishes fast enough to leave her off-balance. Adora doesn't want Catra anywhere near her , now, so she can't brush her fingers through her hair until the lines on her forehead relax.

Catra drops to the ground next to her. "It's okay , I'm sorry ," she says, and it's not her line and it feels just as strange to hear it in her voice now as it had yesterday. Adora pulls her head down. She moves one of her hands over her own mouth, and Catra digs in her nails hard enough not to feel Weaver's palm on her lips. "I didn't mean it, please let me hug you." She's never had to ask before. Begging feels right, she should have to kneel to get anything when she has made Adora this upset.

Adora shakes her head, body heaving, tears on her cheeks again. Catra's made Adora cry more in the last two days than she has in years. She told herself that she wanted Adora to be happy, to think she had the girlfriend she deserves, but Catra's ruined this as badly as she ruins everything. Weaver always said she wanted to hurt Adora and she has. She's a monster , she destroys people, she shouldn't live anymore.

"Please." Catra moves an inch closer and Adora tenses worse. "I- she never did that, you know she never did, for either of us, hugs

weren't something she wanted, and she-" Catra gags, unexpected, "she took what she wanted, but you don't. You're nothing like her."

Adora shudders. Her hand comes away from her face to wrap around her stomach, like she knows she needs it. "I hurt you so much," she chokes, and Catra can only understand her because she's spent so many years playing her voice through her head.

Catra used to be one of Adora's weak spots - that's why Adora broke down when she ran away. Adora hasn't really talked about it, but Bow said they could barely get her to sleep. Catra's willing to press on a bruise if it means Adora will let her in. "Help me," Catra says, and it works, because this time when she closes the gap Adora collapses into her like a wave crashing on the rocks. Her fingers tangle in the shirt over her stomach, temple pinned to the bone between her ribs, pushing like she's trying to get inside. They both cry quiet, usually, but Adora's gasping hard enough that small sounds are starting to leak out, raw and pained, and Adora wouldn't be like this if she hated her.

Catra cradles her head, skull solid, sweat and tears sticking her hair to her face, and her other hand finds Adora's hand to lace their fingers. She talks soft, a line of words that don't have to mean anything but keeps to a rhythm Adora will be able to find under everything, and Catra knows who she learned to do this from. She wonders if Raz used to do it, or if Adora just has an instinct for comforting that Catra never got. "It's okay," she says, "I love you."

It doesn't take long for Adora to go silent, and it's more likely that she's wrestling her reaction down than that she's stopped freaking out. Adora's hair is soft when she runs her hand through it, drifting over her skin better than rice. "You're not like her," she says, and Adora's head shakes hard, once, shoulders jumping under her arm. "You're *not*."

Adora mumbles something into Catra's shirt, breath warm on her chest. "Don't argue with me," Catra says, and she doesn't know if

Adora's reaction is a laugh or not. "I'm right. Y ou don't get a vote if you're going to be wrong about it."

"Sorry ," Adora says, voice still clogged, and she lifts her head so half-heartedly that Catra barely needs pressure to push her back. "I don't - this isn't supposed to be *about* me-"

"T errible opinion, I'm vetoing it," Catra says, and the noise Adora makes sounds like a laugh this time. Adora doesn't seem like she's going to try to get up again, so Catra goes back to combing fingers through her hair. She doesn't know what Adora wants from her , anymore, what their relationship even is if they're not going to act like they're dating anymore, but Adora's letting this happen, so maybe not everything is ruined.

Adora sighs, like dropping something heavy to the floor. "I would've believed you, if you told me," she says. "Y ou know that, right?"

Catra's never been worried that Adora wouldn't believe her . Her biggest fear has always been that, as soon as Adora knows, she'll see the kid who kissed her hair in her sleep for what she was. She hates the brat so much sometimes, wishes someone had killed that thing before it had a chance to grow up, but Adora watched what happened and she's begging her to stay anyway . Adora's listening to her heart thud in her chest right now and she hasn't hurt her on purpose yet.

"I know . That's why I didn't tell you," she says. "I didn't - didn't want-" *you to go*, she thinks, and the words are gone as fast as they came, dripping through her fingers. Adora's hand tightens on hers, and it seems like she understood anyway.

"I was never going to leave you over something W eaver did," Adora says, and it's the first time either of them have said her name since Adora blocked her phone number. Catra expects the name to feel like a blow but it doesn't. "I don't know what I did to make you think I would."

Catra huffs out a breath into Adora's hair. Maybe Adora wants her to stay in her life, but they're not lovers anymore, and she's going to find someone else unless Catra holds her back, makes her sad and alone. "You won't need me when you get a girlfriend," she says, and it's like removing something sharp that cuts on the way out too.

Adora's hand pulses where it's still knotted in the fabric over Catra's stomach. "I thought I had one. Unless you - if you want us to go back to-"

"No," she says, dizzy lightheaded sick. It would have hurt less if Adora punched her. She can't think of many things that sound more desolate than pretending that what they had before was enough. "No."

"Then why wouldn't you be my girlfriend?"

Fifteen minutes ago, it would have made her angry, that Adora was making her say out loud the ways in which she isn't enough for her. That doesn't seem like something Adora would do, right now, face warm through her damp shirt. "You don't want to have sex with me anymore," Catra says, trying not to hope that she's wrong. Maybe Adora changed her mind. Maybe she'd let Catra tell her which things she's only done with Adora, that have no reason to be blared out by her useless brain sometimes. Maybe things can stay mostly the same.

Adora flinches when she says *sex*, and Adora's always been awkward about it until she's too wound up to think herself in circles, but this is worse than usual. She hugs Catra's arm, head still tucked in tight. "I love you more than I care about that," she says, voice rough like she might start crying again. "That's not what this is about for me."

"I don't want you to find someone else." Catra sounds small, even to her own ears, and she hates it. "I'd rather - it's not that bad, it's good sometimes, and even when it isn't I don't-"

"Stop."Adora squeezes her hand so hard it aches, tightens her grip on her arm. It feels like an anchor in a good way , keeping the storm from sweeping her away. Adora doesn't say anything for a moment, and when she does, she sounds like she does when she's pretending she's fine. "I'm not dating you in exchange for sex, Catra. That's not how I want this to work."

whore, the voice in her head says. She feels cold. There's sour at the back of her throat. She can't breathe, can't move. How did she not even know that's what she was doing? Is she just unable to be anything else?

"Hey ,"Adora says, stirring. Maybe she can feel the ice in Catra's core. Maybe her skin's already going cold and waxy . Maybe Adora's starting to see the rot under the surface. "What did I say?"

She doesn't have the air to say it. She's going to throw up if she hears it out loud anyway. At least she was good enough for Adora to keep around. Catra shouldn't have been pretending to be something she wasn't. She's nothing down to her bones.

Adora sits up, pulling away, and Catra's heart spins out, like wheels trying to catch. Adora looks at their laced fingers and Catra should let go, should let her go, and her body isn't something she gets to steer. It's just as well, she can't do anything good with it. Adora says, "Did you - oh. Did I-"

Adora lets go, disappears, and Catra's a stone at the bottom of the lake and if she stops trying to be alive maybe she won't be. Weaver was right about everything - she was everything she said, she was trying to get something from Adora she didn't want to give, she would be better off dead. Hands shift on her skin and they're never going to leave, that's all she is.

Someone's here and the space under the bed is right there but she doesn't hide. It doesn't matter what happens anymore. Something lands on her lap, warm and soft and squirming, and it takes a long moment to realize what it is. She curls over , covering Melog,

shielding them, and they fit perfect in her arms, vibrating and alive. Their nose gets close enough to her face to feel. When she gets enough movement back to pet them, they purr loud enough to drown out the sound of her breathing, relaxed, and that means there's no one here to hurt her, Melog's only this calm around Catra and-

When she looks up, Adora's sitting on the floor a few feet away , typing into her phone. Her eyes are red-rimmed, cheeks blotched, and she holds herself too stiff. Her hair's back up, and her frown tweaks as she bites the inside of her mouth.

"Cut it out with your lip," Catra says, hoarse.

Adora's head snaps up. She does a fake smile, too tired around the edges. "Hey ." Adora clearly means it as an apology , and Catra doesn't have the energy to fight about what is and isn't her fault.

When they finally get back in bed, Adora puts Melog back in her arms, and she puts her hand out next to her like when they were younger, when Catra had spent too long talking through a door and looking at a mask and she freaked out if she felt anything more intense than fabric against her skin, when Adora would ask if she could hug her and she said no.

Adora's never given up on anything in her life. She'll work her fingers to the bone, chase whatever she's stuck on to the ends of the earth. She goes to the mat about all kinds of trivial things, and maybe Catra shouldn't be surprised that she's one of them.

Catra takes the hand, and something uncoils on Adora's face. "W ell figure it out," Adora says, firm through how exhausted she looks. "I promise."

The waiting room is always quiet. Most people are on their phones, and there's a girl, maybe eight, coloring at the short table. Adora tries not to be too obvious about looking away from her. She doesn't like what she remembers when she sees kids anymore.

Catra's playing a game on her phone, swiping through the grid when she finds a word. Her shoulders are up around her ears. Adora was nervous the first time she waited here too. She frowns at her phone. "C-O-T -E isn't a word, is it? Like, that doesn't spell coat, I know that has an A."

"I think it's somewhere birds live? A dovecote is a thing."

"Oh, that's here." Catra swipes and grins. "Yeah, sixteen points."

Adora smiles, the kind that'll pass most of the time. The kid keeps coloring in the corner of her eye. There's other toys on that table too, stretchy noodles and bright silicone that looks like bubble wrap, like the stuff they had in the decompression room in elementary school. She wonders if the kid spends a lot of time somewhere like that, if that's why she's here. There's an adult sitting behind her, and he looks up from his phone occasionally to confirm that the girl is still there. They're fine. The adult brought the kid to see a therapist. He probably takes good care of her. Adora doesn't need to worry about her.

Catra hasn't looked at the kid once. Adora doesn't know if that's good or bad or normal. That's the point of therapy, maybe. When she called the office this morning, they said Angella had made Catra an appointment for this afternoon, in case she changed her mind. They'd have to adjust the time when Catra goes back to work, but she just got her drug test this morning and she's on leave until the results are in.

Adora hasn't told her yet that the police are going to come to talk to them about Weaver, that she'll probably be arrested. She doesn't know how. There's a reason she's here for therapy today, too.

"Adora"?

Darla's standing at the door, ringlets hanging by her ears. Her eyes scan over Catra next to her, who's gone tense so subtly that only Adora would notice.

"One minute," Adora says, because their sessions start at the same time, Catra's therapist should be out any second.

"Go ahead," Catra says, missing the grid when she swipes this time.

Someone else appears in the doorway next to Darla. "Is there a Catra here?" She's short, round, with purple streaks in her hair. She reminds Adora a little of Glimmer.

At first Catra doesn't move. Then her shoulders square, and she stands, stuffing her phone in her pocket. Adora bumps her shoulder with hers. Her face doesn't change, but some of the tension bleeds out of her.

After, they go to the park like they'd planned. Adora runs laps, fast enough and far enough that the endorphins overpower the leftover chill in her chest. When she finally pulls up to the bench where she left Catra and her book, it's empty, but she can make out the shadow in the tree. She stops under the branch, still catching her breath, and waits for Catra's sneaker to tap her shoulder to say that she's ready to go home too. When she looks up at her grinning girlfriend, Catra's hair is catching a little in the breeze, drifting out beside her like it used to.

Chapter End Notes

If you like word puzzles, Catra's playing Squaredle in the last scene.

This is part of a series - the sequel (which is technically a prequel) is also fully written and will start posting next week, also on Fridays. This fic has been added to a series to reflect

that and if you want a notification when the second fic starts you can subscribe there. Thank you for reading, it means a lot to have people coming on this ride with me ♡

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!